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EASTERN BENGAL BALLADS

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[Ramtanu Lahiri Research Fellowship Lectures
for 1924-26; in two Parts]

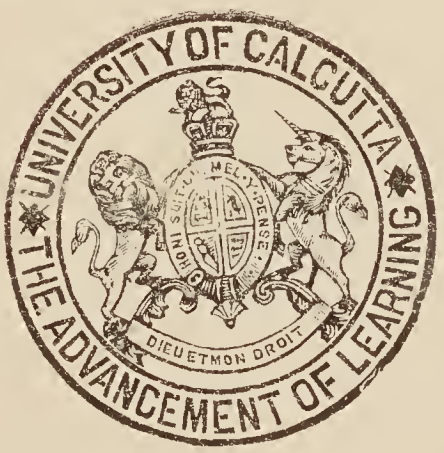
Vol. II : Part I

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PUBLISHED BY THE
UNIVERSITY OF CALCUTTA
1926

PRINTED BY BHUPENDRA LAL BANERJEE
AT THE CALCUTTA UNIVERSITY PRESS, SENATE HOUSE, CALCUTTA

C. U. Press—Reg. No. 156B—July, 1926—750

To

Those who love Bengal

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GENERAL INTRODUCTION.

1. *The Value of the Bengali Ballads.*

Since the publication of the first volume of Eastern Bengal Ballads, we have been able to secure many more of them, full of literary and historical interest. They are as plenty as are the field-flowers and lie strewn all over the country. The Eastern part of the district of Mymensingh, however, owing to its political isolation from the rest of Bengal during the centuries immediately preceding the Muhammadan conquest, and its cultural freedom, untrammelled by the canons of Brahminic renaissance, has preserved the best of these ballads,—a fact which will be evidenced by the love-episodes, contained in the two volumes of ballads, already published by the University. I have described the causes leading to the peculiar advantage of Mymensingh over other districts of Bengal in this respect in my Introduction to the first volume.

The first volume of the ballads was very well received by scholars and orientalists in Europe and India. Lord Ronaldshay, who is as great a scholar as he is an administrator, not only wrote a Foreword to the same but drew the attention of the literary public to these rural songs, by making extracts from them in a learned and interesting article, published in "the Nineteenth Century and After" and in his recent work, "The Heart of Aryyavarta." Scholars like Romain Roland, Sylvain Levi, Grierson and Pargiter have warmly applauded them and the long review published in the Times Literary Supplement has established

the claims of Bengali ballads to a lasting and solid literary fame. Lord Lytton, the worthy scion of an illustrious family of worldwide renown in the domain of Art and Literature, has shown his appreciation of this literary treasure of the province that he has been called upon to rule, by granting a pecuniary aid towards its collection. Mr. E. F. Oaten, the Director of Public Instruction, Bengal, has, ever since the publication of the first volume of ballads, taken a keen interest in this popular literature of Bengal and publicly expressed his high estimate of its merits.

With the help granted by the Government and the University of Calcutta, we have been able to get on our staff four ballad-collectors, at the head of whom stands Babu Chandra Kumar De, whose love for the rural literature of his country is boundless and beyond all praise. His example has inspired the other three men, and a lively spirit has been roused in the countryside for the preservation of these gems of Bengali literature.

2. Ballad of Manwoor Khan.

We have now secured a good many historical ballads, only three or four of which could be published in the present volume. Owing to want of space and urgency for bringing out a second volume, we could not insert in it all of the numerous ballads we have got about Isha Khan, one of the most sturdy champions of liberty in this side of India in the 16th century. The ballad of Manwoor Khan, a great-grandson of Isha Khan that we have secured, is another valuable historical record, which throws much sidelight on the political condition of the country during the latter part of Shah Jehan's rule, unfolding many incidents in the life of Shah Shuja, the unfortunate son of that monarch. These facts are

mostly unknown to historians and though the ballad often becomes legendary in character, mixed up with popular fancy, it must be regarded as actually true in its historical aspects, so far as the main points of its description are concerned. Eastern Bengal is still full of traditions about Shah Shuja. A mosque in Tipperah was built by Govinda Manikya, Raja of Tipperah, and a personal friend of the prince, the cost being borne by the sale of a valuable diamond-ring, which the latter had presented to the Tipperah-Raja. The cost of maintenance of this mosque is met from the endowment of a village, called 'Shuja-Nagar' in Tipperah, named after him,—a gift of Govinda Manikya for the purpose. Prince Shuja was one of the most conspicuous figures at Dacca towards the end of the seventeenth century, where his vicissitudes of fortune and incidents of life have left a lasting impression on the popular mind.

It appears that Shah Shuja, while staying at Dacca in the garden-house of Lall Bagh, was enamoured of a princess, named Sunai, a daughter of Nawab Amir Aly. He proposed to marry her, offering her a dowry of two lakhs of rupees with other presents. But as he was stout and of unwieldy features, his limbs lacking the nimble manly grace of a gallant—worthy of a fashionable lady's love, he could not win the heart of the handsome maiden of Dacca. Her mother, however, favoured the proposal owing to the high status, which such a connection would give her daughter, and marriage-negotiations had considerably advanced. But she absconded in the meantime with Manwoor Khan, who was accomplished and handsome, though his position as Dewan of Jangalbari was certainly far inferior to that of the prince.

Shah Shuja's dogged pursuit of Manwoor Khan, described in this ballad, bristles with interest. With

his own army which was considerable, reinforced by recruits from Murshidabad, he pursued Manwoor Khan, who had been making a precipitous retreat, pursuing a tortuous river-course to avoid Shah Shuja. In a boat, rowed by thirty-two oarsmen, Manwoor Khan passed through the canal of Demra and reached the great expanse of Sitalakha. Having crossed the latter, he came to the Kyatara from where he sent princess Sunai to Jangal Bari, his capital. He next turned his course and arrived at Naraingunj. As soon as Shah Shuja got a report of this, he came with forty armed boats in pursuit of Manwoor Khan who now fled to Barisal. But before Shah Shuja could reach the latter place, Manwoor had fled to Jhalakathi. From Jhalakathi to Khulna and thence to Keshabpur, the pursuer chased the pursued and to very many other places till a full year rolled by. Shah Shuja was wearied of his adventurous pursuit, involving a heavy cost for the maintenance of the army. Food was not always available for them in the out-of-the-way places, visited during the fruitless search, and he was obliged to dismiss them, retaining only fifty picked warriors. But so great had been his rage at his disappointment in love that he did not give up his pursuit inspite of all hardships. Manwoor Khan, in the meantime, had reached the small island of Sandwip in the Bay of Bengal. Shah Shuja all unexpectedly arrived there so that his enemy was taken by absolute surprise. The latter entered a Musjid there, of which the sacred walls offered him shelter—where he could not be molested by his enemy. The prince did not violate the rules of the sanctuary but surrounded it with his fifty men, confident that Manwoor Khan would find no way of escape and would eventually be starved to death. Full twenty-one days passed and there was

no sign of any living being in the mosque. Shah Shuja, at this stage, ordered its doors to be opened by force, being certain that Manwoor Khan, the young Dewan of Jangal Bari, had died.

But when the door was broken open, the commanding figure of the Dewan, though reduced by hunger, was observed at the gateway, wielding his sword with a dexterity which baffled the attempts of many of the prince's soldiers to get hold of his person. Wonder-struck at this valorous conduct of his famished foe, Shah Shuja gazed with surprise and admiration at the handsome and majestic appearance of the Dewan. He ordered his men to withdraw and graciously pardoned the Jangal Bari-chief. They now became fast friends and conceived the plan of jointly attacking the Burmese king of Chittagong, which was not very far from Sandwip.

Shah Shuja gained a victory here, mainly owing to a stratagem, by which Manwoor Khan had killed the Burmese king Rahangam and succeeded in spreading a consternation in his army.

The prince and Manwoor Khan looted the palace, which yielded valuable treasure, a part of which was given to the Dewan. Two boats, full of valuables, were sent to Jangalbari.

The Burmese citizens were mostly driven away from Chittagong by the heroes. Those amongst them, who embraced Islam, were allowed to live there. Many good Muhammadans were brought from the neighbouring countries and made to settle at Chittagong under Shah Shuja's orders. They obtained Lakhraj (rent-free) lands as gifts from the prince, "Even now," Says the ballad-maker, "these lands stand as lakhraj-properties of their owners,—at one time granted by

Shah Shuja." The town was given the name of Islamabad, after Islam had thus obtained a firm footing there. Many towns and markets were established in the district by the two glorious heroes, and these have since flourished.

After this adventure, the prince and the Dewan came back to Naraingunj where they parted—Manwoor going to his own town of Jangalbari and the prince to Rajmahal. "At this time," Says the ballad-maker in a sad tone, "Shah Shuja was destined to meet his tragic end, well known in the pages of history."

From a poem by Syed Alwal, we come to know of the developments that took place at Arakan, where prince Shaq Shuja had fled after his defeat at the hands of Aurangzeb. But this is no episode of our ballad-literature. So we refrain from noticing it here. We have, however, come across some lines of an old ballad, in which there is a humorous reference to a daughter of Shah Shuja falling in love with a Burmese Prince during his stay in that country.

We are sorry, for shortness of space we could not insert the ballad of Manwoor Khan in this volume.

3. *Struggle of the Bhuian Rajas for Independence.*

A spirit of revolt against the Delhi-suzerain seems to have been rampant in Bengal in the 16th and 17th centuries. The Bāra Bhuians, or the twelve sub-lords of Bengal were practically independent and wielded a great power. Besides the Nawabs of Bengal themselves often tried to throw off the imperial yoke when an opportunity presented itself. Daud Khan and Katlu Khan had lost their lives in such attempts, but Sher Shah became successful.

Isha Khan, one of the Bhuian lords, had many a tough fight with the Imperial army, led by Shahbaz Khan and Man Sinha. The conciliatory spirit, that characterised the administration of Akbar, eventually subdued the chief of Jangalbari by an offer of friendship. His great-grandson, Manwoor Khan, as is proved by the accounts given above, conducted his hostilities against Shah Shuja with courage and tact, having even dared to carry off a princess, who was practically betrothed to the latter. The ballad of Feroz Khan proves in an undoubted manner how acutely the yoke of Delhi oppressed the souls of these Baiswara Rajput chiefs, converted to Islam. It is said that the young Dewan lost all taste for food and spent sleepless nights over the thought of his political thraldom, which obliged him to pay an annual revenue to the Delhi-Court. He decided to stop payment of the revenue and was on the eve of a revolt, convinced that such a course would, in all probability, involve his ruin. The story of Chand Rai and that of his brother Kedar Rai are a record of incessant struggle to assert independence, and at least one of them lost his life in an affray with the Imperial army under Man Sinha. But the figure of Pratap Aditya rises far above these glorious rebels in bravery and indomitable spirit of an unyielding patriotism. The words with which he answered the Delhi-ambassador when the latter handed him fetters and a sword as alternatives, wishing him to accept either at his choice—the one indicating his submission to the throne of Delhi and the other his wish to meet the Imperial army in battle—are characteristically significant. Pratap Aditya said, "I return the fetters. With these bind the feet of your own master at Delhi. I accept the sword ; after my victory, I will wash off its blood-stain in the waters of the Jumna."

The sub-lords of Bengal were verily like wild leopards and in their struggle for independence, they hardly showed a spirit of compromise. Pratap Aditya, after winning many victories in the field, was at last killed by Man Sinha. The last of these champions of freedom was Raja Sitaram Rai, the relics of whose palace are still to be seen at Mahmudpur in the district of Jessore. But these are not all ; we learn from Vaishnaba history that Raja Vira Hambir of Vaishnupur had attempted to lead an expedition against the Nawab of Murshidabad, and Raja Chand Rai of Gaur Dwar (not the hero of Sripur) was so powerful that the Pathan king Katlu Khan did not venture to send his revenue-collectors to his city for recovering his arrear-dues. The Rajmala records the victories that some of the old monarchs of Tipperah won over the kings of Gaur, helped by the Imperial force.

During the 16th and 17th centuries Bengal was in a troubled state and the Hindu sub-lords had practically become independent, defying the powers of the Nawab of Gaur and sometimes aspiring to the still higher glory of throwing off the Delhi-yoke.

Bengali women have often shown heroic and romantic traits of character in these ballads, but the character of Sakhina attains a towering eminence not only by her devotion to husband, which was so great that she did not even shrink from fighting with her own father for its sake, but by the triumphant victory that she won over the Delhi army, disguised as a young soldier. All the while, however, the feminine grace of her character was in evidence, which reached its flowering point at her death, caused by a letter of divorce. The field of Kellatajpur in the sub-division of Kishoregunj (Mymensingh) still bears the spot, where the heroic

woman fought like a lioness and died of a broken heart like a fragile woman that she was.

4. *Connection of the Ballads with old Bengali-Literature, especially with the Vaishnava Literature.*

These ballads have opened our eyes to an altogether new chapter in the history of Bengali literature. The rustic songs are permeated by deep poetry, presenting to us vividly the varying shades of popular mentality in Bengal. The poets of the Renaissance have written classical works, which are now recognised as land-marks in our literature. But however highly some of them might have been admired when their authors lived, the true test of their excellence and abiding interest lies in the relation which they bear to the ballads. However Sanskritised they may be in form, the more they approach the spirit and the language of the ballads, the greater is their appeal to the popular mind. Their gorgeous exterior dazzled the eyes of their contemporaries at one time, but their genuineness and claims to permanent poetic fame should be judged not by their rich loans from Sanskrit, but from the way in which they have been able to depict popular sentiments of which these ballads are the nurseries.

Take for instance the Vaishnava literature of Bengal. A student unfamiliar with the ballads will hardly be able to trace the history of Bengal Vaishnavism. The ballads show romantic love, kindred to that which the Sahajiyas have developed. Chandidas says, "Every one of our time aspires to be a Sahajiya. But how many of us know the true significance of that creed?" This statement of the great poet of the fourteenth century, proves that the Sahajiya creed was in a flourishing condition in Bengal during this period. For illustration of this fact one should read the ballads of the young Herdsman,

the Washer-maiden, Kanchanmala and Lila, published in this volume. They show men and women, strikingly the latter, inspired by a spirit of romantic love. They are beautiful poems, having a natural flavour of their own, and belonging as they do to the secular plane, they do not seem to owe anything directly to the Sahajiya propaganda which bears the hall-mark of the spiritual. But all the same, they evince a kindred spirit and prove beyond doubt that the atmosphere of Bengal of that age was permeated by a spirit of freedom in sexual relation, which though it reached the highest and the best conceivable perfection, was not yet reckoned as a spiritual force. The whole province of Bengal lay under the spell of this romantic love, showing a higher sacrifice for the beloved than is to be found even in mediæval knight-errantry. It gives rise to stormy emotions of the soul and is assuredly a result of *tapasyā* for which I do not find an adequate expression in English.

The ballads show that Bengal was slowly preparing itself for the message of Chaitanya Deva—the message of divine love. Great hardship and self-sacrifice, verging on martyrdom are in evidence everywhere, this being a dominant feature especially in the characters of the heroines. This form of secular but highly romantic love was idealised by Chandidas till Chaitanya came forward to give it a spiritual interpretation and elevate it to a superior plane. He said, "Yes, Radha loved Krishna and abandoned all for her beloved cowherd. But Radha is the human soul and Krishna is none other than the Great One, who wants all men to love Him with all their might." The ballads bear no trace of Vaishnava influence whatever. In their crude language and complete independence of all religious ideas and propagandism, they stand alone as theoffspring of a school a different from all others. Though romantic, they seldom rise above the earth, and one familiar with

Vaishnava poetry will find them in no sign of any connection with the ballads. Chronologically speaking, some of the ballads might be anterior to Chandidas, but most of them are of a later period. No wave of Vaishnava thought seems to have reached the rustic huts, where the ballads were sung. How are we then to account for the fact that occasionally we find the very lines of Chandidas and other Vaishnava poets occurring in them? The situation and environment of lovers described in these ballads occasionally show a striking similarity with the incidents of Radha-Krishna love. The ballads are evidently, as I have stated, a quite independent literature. How are we to account for the unmistakably striking agreement between the two in verbal forms?

Now we are going to illustrate our remark by some specific cases, which show this concurrence most prominently. It is well known that of all Vaishnava poets, Chandidas uses the archaic language of the country-folk with the most happy effect. Though a great Sanskrit scholar himself, his poems seldom indulge in classical display, but they throb with the life and sentiments of the people; and his finest lyrics are those wherein he depicts the joys, sorrows and felicitous emotions of his race and cares not for displaying a mastery over Sanskritic style or the canons of Sanskrit poetics, as he does in the first offspring of his poesy—the Krishna Kirtan. This rural element in his thought and language constitutes the strength and special feature of his poetry. Here in this literature of ballads, we find many sentences and phrases, which will at once recall the poetry of Chandidas. I will mention some striking cases of these. In the song of the Washer-maiden (12-30), we have the line "জিহ্বার সঙ্গে দাঁতের পীরিতি, আর ছলাতে কাটে" (It is like the friendship between the teeth and the tongue, the former do not fail to bite the latter on some

pretext or other). We have a similar line in Chandidas almost in the very words of the ballad-maker, "জিহ্বার সঙ্গেতে দাঁতের পীরিতি, সময় পাইলে কাটে." In the same ballad, the line "তোমার চরণে আমার শতেক পরণাম" (Canto 24) will remind one of the famous song of Chandidas, "তোমার চরণে বঁধু শতেক পরণাম। তোমার চরণে বঁধু লিখ আমার নাম॥ লিখিতে দাসীর নাম লাগে যদি পায়। মাটিতে লিখিয়া নাম, চরণ দিও তায়." One of the most popular songs of Chandidas begins with the lines, "সুখের লাগিয়া এ ঘর বাঁধিনু অনলে পুড়িয়া গেল। অমিয়া-সাগরে সিনান করিতে সকলি গরল ভেল." The whole idea contained in the above is breathed in the following lines of the ballad of Bhelua ;—the imagery is not the same, but the idea is strikingly similar, whereas the language of the ballads is simpler, more direct and homely, "গাছের তলায় আইলাম ছায়া পাইবার আশে। পত্র ছেইদ্যা রৌদ্র লাগে আপন কর্ম্মদোষে।" "ঘরেতে পাতিলাম শয্যা নিদ্রার কারণ। সেই ঘরে লাগিল আগুণ কপালে লিখন." The ballad of the Washer-maiden describes a situation where the princely youth, her lover, exposes himself to rain, and she, while feeling extreme pain at the suffering of her lover for her sake, cannot come out to meet him, as the elders of the house have not yet gone to sleep, and she deplores her lot in a soliloquy (2, 6-10). A situation like this gives the occasion for Chandidas's popular song, "এ ঘোর রজনী মেঘের ঘটা, কেমনে আইলা বাটে। আঙ্গিনার মাঝে, বঁধুয়া ভিজিছে, দেখে যে পরাণ ফাটে." The one seems evidently like the counter-part of the other. The lines "কাট্যা গেছে কাল মেঘ চাঁদের উদয়। এই পথে যেতে গেলে কুলমানের ভয়॥" (Washer-maiden, 2-18) will remind one of Chandidas's "কহিও বঁধুরে সই কহিও বঁধুরে। গমন বিরোধী হ'ল পাপ শশধরে॥" The many exquisite lines addressed to the flute and the effect of its sound, that we find in the Herdsman-lover (4, 47-62) are just like those which we so often meet with in Chandidas's lyrics,—the sweetest

one being the song in the Krishna Kirtan, which begins with, "কে না বাঁশী বাএ, বড়ায়ি যমুনাণঈ কূলে."

Not only Chandidas, but many other Vaishnava poets have written in a style in which the phraseology of our ballad-poetry occurs again and again. The unmatched beauty of Jnana Das's famous line, "ঢল ঢল কাঁচা অঙ্গের লাবণী অবনী বহিয়ে যায়" has many a parallel in the ballad-literature. For instance, "অঙ্গের লাবণী সোনাইর বাইয়া পড়ে ভূমে" (Dewan Bhabana, 2-12), "হাঁটিতে ভাঙ্গিয়া পড়ে অঙ্গের লাবণী" (Bhelua, 2, 23) and "হাটিতে মাটিতে ভাসে অঙ্গের লাবণী" (Isha Khan, 2, 17). The line "কাল দিন চল্যা গেল কাল হ'ল কাল" (Washer-maiden, 9-42), sounds like an echo of Vidyapati's "কাল অবধি বঁধুঁ গেল।...ভেল পরভাত পুছই সবহুঁ। কহ কহ রে সখি কালি কবহুঁ॥" Lochan Das's song "এস এস বঁধু এস," etc., popularised by Bankim Chandra in his "*Kamala Kanter Daptar*" has the line, "ফুল নহ যে কেশের করি বেশ." This idea we find again and again in the ballad-literature, for example, in "ফুল যদি হইতারে বঁধু ফুল হইতা তুমি। কেশেতে ছাপাইয়া রাখতাম, ঝার‍্যা বান্‌তাম বেণী॥" (Mahua 8-22), in "পুষ্প হ'লে প্রাণের বঁধু খোপায় রাখতাম তোরে।" (Dewan Bhabana, 4-26) and in "পুষ্প হ'লে বঁধুয়ারে গাথ্যা রাখতাম গলে" (Kamala p. 162). Gopal Uré, whose Yātrā-songs enjoyed a great popularity among the Bengalis in the early part of the nineteenth century, has some beautiful lines, the original of which comes to us as a surprise from the ballads. "ভোমরা আছিলা তুমি হৈলা গোবরিয়া" occurs in the Washer-maiden's song (8-19), composed about the 14th century, and the corresponding line in the very language of the ballad-poetry, we find in "গোবরা পোকা হইয়া বসিলি পদ্মে" of Gopal Uré.

We believe that the ballad-poetry did not supply the Vaishnava poets with these fine ideas. Nor did the ballad-makers copy from Vaishnava-poetry. Both got the ideas and the beautiful language in which we find

them couched, from the rich phraseology of emotional poetry with which Bengal in those days abounded—a sequel to the romantic love with which the very atmosphere of this country was charged, due partly to the culture spread by the Sahajiyas. The ballad-makers and the Vaishnava-poets attacked a common source, the rural poetical phraseology current in the air of Bengal ; so that every poet who studied life, and not the Sanskrit classics alone, got the vivid images and this finished poetical language first-hand from his own hearth and home. The material was before the poets, if they only cared to utilise and not contemptuously reject it as a rustic thing beneath notice.

The ballad-literature shows us how deep-rooted in the soil is the Vaishnava-religion, founded by Chaitanya. It took centuries for the Bengali-people to fit them by emotional culture for receiving the love-messages of the apostle of Nadia. The higher emotion developed by the Bengali race, leading to noble sacrifices and martyrdoms, as we find in the ballads, was not "a rosy path of dalliance" with them. It was not a mere fashion of the age favoured by the dandies of society. It was a *tapasya*, a spiritual training under the garb of sexual romance, making the youth of both the sexes undergo all sacrifices and renunciations in the spirit of saints. Sexual love was thus gradually idealised, and when Chaitanya came forward to declare that it had no saving power except as an allegory of Divine Love, the people found no difficulty in receiving his interpretation, as the soil was already prepared for it.

Vaishnavism of Bengal, therefore, did not come from the south,—the home of Ramanuja ; neither did it come from Madhyacharya, *alias* Ananda tirtha, born in 1191 A.D., though it is popularly ascribed to

him. It was a product of the soil, over which the very life-blood of men and women was shed for centuries and which was fertilised by tears—the offspring of self-less action. The ballad-literature of Bengal mirrors the *tapasya* of the people in the domain of emotion. And it was for this reason that Chaitanya's religion found a ready response in the country, and the lyrics of Vaishnava-masters had such a powerful appeal for the people. This Vaishnava-religion of Bengal arose out of the ashes of the martyrs of both sexes in the cause of love—Chaitanya turning the angle of vision from earth to a higher world.

But the connection of the ballads with our old literature does not cease here. If we scrutinise these popular songs, we will find in them the ground-work of the whole fabric of our past literature. We find lines and passages in them, which correspond to the texts of the aphorisms of Dāk and Khanā, the Maināmati songs, the Bengali Ramayanas, the Kabikankan Chandi, in fact, of all the best works of the old school. This establishes the indigenous character and homogeneity of our old literature. It seems that the common stock of the felicitous language of emotion, perfected in the countryside, did not supply the ballad-maker and the Vaishnava-poet alone with rich material, but also all other poets of the old school in every sphere of our literature. The ballads prove the existence of a common source, which offered to the old Bengali writers ideas and also the suitable language to convey them. We will illustrate our remark by references. In the Herdsman-lover (11-12), we find the lines, "ভরা কলসীর জল জমীনে ফেলিয়া। জলের ঘাটে যায় কন্যা কলসী লইয়া." The parallel will be found in the line of the aphorisms of Dāk "পানি ফেলি পানিকে যায়" (Typical Selections, Vol. I, p. 8). The

lines, "তুমি হও তরুরে বঁধু আমি হই লতা। বেইড়া রাখর যুগল চরণ ছাইড়া যাবে কোথা॥" (Kanka-o-Lila, p. 250) agrees almost *verbatim* with the appeal of Aduna to Gopichandra in the Mainamati-Songs:—"তুমি হবু বটবৃক্ষ আমি তোমার লতা। রাঙ্গা চরণ বেড়িয়া রমু ছাড়িয়া যাইবা কোথা." The lines "মুষ্টিতে আটয়ে লীলার চিকণ কাঁকালি" (Kanka-o-Lila, Canto V) and "মুষ্টিতে ধরিতে পারি কটিখানি সরু" (Kamala, 3-7) have their parallel in "মুষ্টিতে ধরিতে পারি সীতার কাঁকালি" (Kṛttivasa) and the lines "মনে বিষ মুখে মধু এতেক কহিয়া। ভেলুয়ার নিকটে গেল বিদায় মাগিয়া॥" (Bhelua, p. 50) will remind one of "মনে বিষ মুখে মধু জিজ্ঞাসে ফুল্লরা। ক্ষুধা তৃষ্ণা দূরে গেল রন্ধনের ত্বরা॥" of Kabikankan. We have quoted only stray passages to prove our point. Some of the finest passages of many a distinguished Bengali poet of the old school will be accounted for and traced in the current phraseology of popular literature, composed by illiterate rustics. The spring of poetry was in the heart of the masses—in the artless souls of the rural people. From this source flowed the current of Vaishnava-thought, purified by philosophy and science on the one hand, and some of the exquisite ideas of our Renaissance-literature enlivened by words of Sanskritic importation on the other. The ballads open the portals of the history of our cultural development in various spheres of literary activities and possess more than their poetic value, unfolding the latent forces that created and developed our literature.

The few historical ballads, given in this volume, may be found lacking in poetical interest. But they are valuable as illuminating some of the obscure corners of the history of Bengal. We have reserved a number of ballads of this kind for insertion in the third volume.

The song of the Washer-maiden, that of Kanchanmala, of Lila and the incomplete ballad of the Herdsman-lover are, however, the finest examples of lyrical poetry

in the field of ballads, occasionally rising to a sublime epic-height by the grandeur of the character of the heroines.

An instance of glorious poetry occurs in the ballad of Rani Kamala, which we have found in an incomplete shape based on an historical incident, mixed up with a mystic legend-lore. The ovation it gives to the Dawn (Rani Kamala, 10, 1-11), when the Sun-God descends from his golden chariot and, taking his bath in the sea, scatters the golden particles from its wheels as he commences his journey of the day, is glowing in its primitive simplicity and is as grand as the Riks, addressed to the Goddess Ushā in the Vedas. It shows the noble conception of a poetic soul face to face with Nature, and is entirely free from the trammels of rhetorical convention.

Munshi Jasimuddin has sent me another version of the ballad of Rani Kamala, which gives a different account of the preliminary portion of this story.

In the version published herein the queen requests the Raja to excavate a pond, as a token of his love for her, which would be of the size of the whole length of a *takua* of thread to be spun by her in seven days.

In the version supplied by Jasimuddin we find the Raja and the Rani engaged in playing dice—the condition being that should the Raja win, the Rani must induce her parents to give her sister in marriage to the Raja. As polygamy was the fashion of the day, and marrying a sister-in-law, unlike the custom in some western countries, is sanctioned by society in India, there was nothing unusual or unfair in this condition. On the other side, if the Rani would win, the Raja was to excavate a pond in her name. Its size was to be determined by the range of the sound of a drum to be

beaten by the drummer attached to the palace with his utmost strength.

The Rani won the play. At that particular moment the accumulated revenue of the Raj due to the Imperial treasury of Delhi was outstanding for some years, and it had to be paid without delay. The sound of the drum, if the drummer would beat with his utmost power, might be heard from a distance of two miles. To excavate a pond of such a vast dimension would involve an expenditure that could not be met from the funds at the Raja's disposal at that hour of financial stress. So he privately ordered the drummer to beat his drum low, so that the sound might not go very far.

Another point of difference between the two versions is that instead of the Raja dreaming the dream which made his consort to sacrifice her life, the dream was dreamt by the Rani herself in the unpublished ballad. This takes away the stigma of cruelty that might be attributed to the Raja for unfolding his dream to the Rani.

The version secured by Jasimuddin thus gives a more rational account of the story. But the present version is more poetical and possesses a higher literary value. The historian may give credit to Jasimuddin's version, but the literary public will enjoy the one that is published here much better.

I must, however, speak apologetically of the poor quality of my translation. The refined emotional language of the Bengali people, in its niceties of expression, is hardly capable of felicitous translation into a language which, inspite of its unmatched richness, does not seem to me to be equally tender. Besides this, the translator is keenly aware of his limitations in regard to English language. The short ballad of Lila is full of niceties of tender expression, and adequate

language could not be found for preserving the beauty of the original. The long poem of Bhelua is comparatively dull, but occasionally rises to a lyrical excellence by dint of the country-dialect, which, divested of its original garb, has become poor in my translation.

Great difficulties have been experienced by me in translating the emotional poetry of Bengal and I may be permitted to refer to some of them here. There is no equivalent word in English for the Bengali word মান. The indescribable sweetness attached to the Bengali word, which under the thin veneer of anger tries to attract rather than repel, is not conveyed by any word that I know of even in the other Indian Vernaculars, not to speak of English. The words রঙ্গিণী and অনুরাগিণী lose all their sweetness in translation. It is vain to expect an equivalent for the extremely tender Bengali word সোহাগ. Climatic conditions of Bengal give a peculiar charm to some words here which is missed in translation. For instance the word শীতল bears more than its face-value and implies the tenderness of a healing balm in this tropical climate of ours. How can the extreme tenderness of the word in such lines as "শীতল তছু অঙ্গ পরশ রস-লালসে" (Jnan Das) and "এস প্রেমময়ি, পরাশিয়ে অঙ্গ শীতল হই" (Krishna Kamal) be conveyed in English. The English word 'cooling' hardly gives an adequate idea. The word 'জুড়ানু' is another such word. Then in a tropical country mere names of the months 'ভাদর' and 'শাঞ্চণ' recall to the mind picturesque landscape-scenes with the vividness of a kaleidoscopic show and this can be ill brought out by such words as September and October. The word রাঙ্গা in "রাঙ্গা পা দুখানি," conveying to the Bengali mind the associations of the red dye আল্‌তা or the colour of the lotus with which the feet are generally compared, loses all its sweetness, nay verges on the grotesque if we translate it by

the English word "red." There are hundreds of such words in the field of emotional poetry over which the translators will halt. They will vainly strive to find suitable equivalents for these in English. And added to this is my own imperfect knowledge of English which has, as I have already said, been a great hindrance.

There are four kinds of ballads that we could lay our hands upon from the countryside.

The first kind of these is of the nature of Mainámati songs. Superstitious beliefs in miracles, rustic and crude conventions, grotesque scenes and incongruities and faith in the Siddhás, who, like the Druids, could accomplish extraordinary feats of jugglery, form the essential features of this school of ballads. Tantrikism is the underlying principle of these. And the Buddhist Tantriks, when accepting Islam, could not shake off their belief in the miraculous power of Tantrik action. We have got many Tantrik-works written by Muhammadans in Bengali from Chittagong. This kind of ballads may be compared to the Gaelic songs. An element of intense poetry is not, however, altogether lacking in this class of popular songs, though such instances are few and far between. In the present volume, the ballad of Nizam Dacoit belongs to this school. I have found a long printed poem on the dacoit who latterly turned a saint, composed by a rustic poet anxious to display his pedantry. This poem lacks the beauty of simple and direct expression, which forms the *forte* of all genuine Bengali ballads. The present one is fresh from countryside and though comparatively dull, it has not been spoiled or distorted by unskilled hands, trying to improve the diction. Though written by a Muhammadan it has all the characteristics of the ballads of this kind composed by the Hindus about their own

saints. There is, however, one thing in it, which shows its difference of conception from the Hindu standpoint. The dacoit is said to have shortened the period of his trial by two murders. Though the Gītā would support such an idea, the Hindus of rural Bengal would never extol a murder, however laudable the purpose may be. I do not say that the Moslem ethical point of view is wrong or that the teachings of the Gītā should be discarded, as regards the merits of a martial deed in a noble cause. But my belief is that an unprejudiced Hindu writer of Bengal during the last five or six centuries of the growth and development of Vaisnava ideas in the country, would never advocate assassination even for the best of purposes. The ballad of Nizam Dacoit shows indifferent poetry, though it is extensively popular among the Muhammadans in some parts of Bengal.

The ballads of the second class are historical. I have given three of them in this volume and the small ballad on Santal insurrection may also be classed under this head. It records an event which caused considerable local consternation in the western frontier of Bengal more than half a century ago. It is not, however, a very important ballad. I must say here that through inadvertence this little poem, though belonging to western Bengal, has found a place in this volume which bears the name of "Eastern Bengal Ballads."

The third class, which is by far the best of all, is represented by the love-ballads of the romantic school, of which we have spoken at some length. Though I have found scraps of verses from this kind of ballads—sometimes only a few lines of them—from other districts of Bengal, the best and the most complete ones are to be found in Eastern Mymensingh alone. Brahminic Renaissance drove away these gems of rustic literature

from all other parts of Bengal, because the spirit of romantic love propagated in them ran counter to the strict conservatism of the later school of Hinduism, which totally curbed the liberty of women. These songs were allowed to linger in Eastern Mymensingh, where Brahminic Renaissance could not assert itself for some centuries. In other parts of Bengal, ballads like those of Mahuā, Maluā and Washer-maiden lost favour and were suppressed, and in their places, the stories of Sita and Savitri, of Prahlad and Dhruva, of Nala and Damayanti and the heroic Pandavas, claimed high favour in popular estimation, due to the stress, put upon '*Bhakti*' or devotion in later times, and to the dissemination of orthodox Brahminic ideas, curbing the liberty of the fair sex. But as we have found mere unconnected, scraps of romantic love-songs, (now lost) belonging to a preceding age, still lingering in the memory of the rustics of all districts of Bengal, we are convinced that they had once flourished throughout the province, previous to Brahminic renaissance. The most striking of the ballads of this school in some points, though decidedly not one of the very best of them, is the ballad "The Adventurous career of a young Dacoit." It gives a fresh account of country-life on the banks of the great rivers of Eastern Bengal, of a love-romance, full of the freedom and flavour of rural scenes—with much quaint humour and varied scenes of action, giving us glimpses into the social history and family-life of the cottagers of Bengal, as was to be found two centuries ago. Though it does not possess that appeal to higher emotions, which the best ones of this kind of ballads do, it possesses a singular charm for the variety of scenes of thrilling interest introduced, and the valorous, resourceful character of the heroine, unfortunately stranded midway,

as a complete version of this remarkable ballad has not been found. Its archaic language will be of great interest to the students of philology.

The fourth kind of ballads is to be found in the numerous printed books, which form the bulk of Moslem rustic literature. These publications are generally found to give distorted versions of popular ballads. The writers, anxious to make a show of their little learning, change the simple words of original ballads and thus spoil their pristine grace and beauty. They introduce moreover absurd pedantries and erotic descriptions,—the characteristics of eighteenth century Bengali literature,—converting the simple narrations of unassuming rural poets into absurd artificialities and conventional forms of a school of poetry that has justly lost all favour with our people, and is now quite out of fashion.

5. *A description of the ships referred to in the ballads—Pictures and illustrations.*[1]

In the literature of the ballads there are good many references to country boats and ships on board of which the enterprising people of the district of Chittagong make sea-voyages for trading purposes. Ship-building in Chittagong is an art of great antiquity. Bangsidas, the celebrated poet of the Manasa cult, who wrote his poem in 1575 A.D., gives a graphic description as to how the great sea-going vessels were constructed in Bengal in olden times. The poet was a native of Mymemsingh,

[1] Babu Asutosh Choudhury, one of our ballad-collectors has supplied me with elaborate notes on the ships and country-boats of Chittagong, which have materially helped me in writing this account. The photographs of sloops and ships given here have been supplied by him.

the land of great rivers like the Brahmaputra, the Kangsa, the Dhanu, and the Bhairab. The old ships of Chittagong once carried the wealthy merchants of Bengal to China, Ceylon, Maladives, Lacadives, Java, Balli, Cochin and to the coasts of the Arabian Sea. There were many architects and sculptors of Bengal who co-operated with the Kalingas in carrying out the artistic designs of the great Buddhist sanctuary known as the Barabodar Temple of Java and of the sublime Hindu figures in the Prahmva-banam in the Island of Balli. Earliest of these works carry us to the 3rd and 4th centuries A.D. These travellers of the high seas assuredly marched on board the ships constructed by the Balamis on the banks of the Karnafuli in Chittagong. The descendants of these Hindu architects still follow the avocation of ship-building, though the glorious achievements of their fore-fathers are now reduced to mere day-dreams;—the humble avocation of the present-day Balamis is to build large and small country boats and ships of ordinary dimensions and workmanship which still carry the merchants of Bengal to the small Islands of the Bay for trading purposes. At one time the Sultan of Turkey, dissatisfied with the method of ship-building in Alexandrian dock-yards, used to give order for ships to the builders of Chittagong. This we learn on the authority of the Chinese traveller Mahunda. The celebrated Arabian writer Edris who flourished in the twelfth century called Chittagong by the name of 'Karnabul.' This word is no doubt a corruption of the Karnafuli on the banks of which the Balamis constructed ships and so popularised the name of their river among foreigners as to make them call the whole district after it. De Burrarghs, the celebrated Portuguese writer alludes to the commercial transactions carried on between Chittagong and Arabia in ancient

times. Many Arabian Dervishes and Pirs came to Chittagong on board the vessels built in that country. In 1405 Cheng Ho, the Chinese minister, was sent to the port of Chittagong by his king for the settlement of some commercial disputes, and in 1443 the Arabian traveller Ebn Batatu came to Chittagong and travelled on board one of her ships to Java and thence to China. In 1553 Nanu de Chona, the Governor of Goa, sent one of his generals, De Manna, at the head of two hundred men and five ships for establishing a trading centre at Chittagong. Ship-building in Chittagong has had thus a glorious record since a remote point of antiquity till only recent times. Hunter says that the great art of the country was ousted, failing in competition with European vessels conducted by steam-engine on scientific methods, from after 1875.

The tradition of some of the wealthy and enterprising merchants of Chittagong, who flourished during the declining days of Moslem supremacy, has been preserved in the country. We have heard of the famous merchants Rangya Basir, Gumani Malum, Madan Kerani, Dataram Chaudhuri and others who lived in that period,—some of them owning a hundred ships. When the Portuguese pirates carried on marauding expeditions in Chittagong, the merchants of the place created a defence force by means of their sloops which heroically resisted the attack of the pirates. This united body of sloops went by the name of 'Sloop Bahar' and a port of that name still exists near the town of Chittagong. The hero who distinguished himself in this defence was called the 'Bahardār.' In the early part of the 19th century many merchants owned a good number of ships in Chittagong. Piru Saudagar, Nasu Malum and Ram Mohun Daroga were the most eminent of these. One of the ships of the last named person once went for trade up to the port of the Tweed in Scotland.

I have already stated that the ballads are full of references about these ships and country-boats of Chittagong. In the ballad of the Washer maiden, there is an interesting description of the ships of Tamasā Gazi, carrying an extensive trade in rice. The ballad of Bhelua literally bristles with accounts of ships. Among the many interesting things described in it are to be found accounts of a peculiar custom among a section of local merchants—of the bride and bridegroom elect being married on board the great merchant-vessels in the high seas. The ballad of the Herdsman Lover refers to the voyages of Meghua, the wicked merchant of Chittagong. We have had accounts of the unfortunate prince Shah Suja in the ballad of Mannoor Khan. Shah Suja, it is well-known in Burma, fled from Araccan on board a Balam ship of Chittagong. In the small ballad of (গৌরমণি মাঝির ভাসান) (the voyages of Gourmani, the boatman), there is a description of a fishing excursion in the Bay of Bengal on a Godhu boat, and in the ballad of স্বরূপ জেলের বারমাসী[1] (Accounts of twelve months on the sea of Svarup, the fisherman) there is a similar description.

As, therefore, in the ballad literature—nay in the whole of the old Bengali literature—there are numerous references to sea-voyages, and as the Chittagong ships and country boats were pre-eminently the best of the lot and have up to now preserved the old tradition, though in an humble scale, I take the liberty of giving a detailed account of these ships and country boats with illustrations.

1. The *Balam* and the *Godhu* boats are by far the most common in Chittagong in the present day. Their pattern has remained unaltered from a great antiquity and though they are mere boats of an humble size, not

[1] These two ballads have not yet been published.

furnished with any modern scientific equipments, they are not afraid of running abreast the high seas sometimes for five or six months together. The Balam boats are built by Balamis who have also lent their name to a particular kind of rice in which they traded. These boats even now go to Araccan, Kaikfu and other ports of Burma, their principal article being rice (see Fig. XI). The biggest of the Balam boats of the present day have the capacity to carry 200-250 tons of goods. They are, however, granted license for only 50 tons of goods when journeying in the Bay. In olden times their capacity and size were of course immensely greater. The Balam has sixteen oars attached it, but it chiefly depends on the sail.

2. *The Godhu boats.*[1]—these also like the Balams are very ancient. A full-shaped Godhu complete in all its parts, is to be found in the Bay up to March and April of the year. The parts of the boat are disjointed after April, when the keels are separated from the upper parts and kept safe in the dock. The parts are jointed again in October when the boats are floated once more in water The fishing excursions referred to in the ballads are carried on in the Godhu boats. The Godhu generally speaking carries 25-30 men and goes for fishing to various Islands in the Bay such as সোনা দিয়া (The Golden Island), লাল দিয়া (The Red Island), রাঙ্গা বালী (Red Sands) and other small Islands which are completely submerged under saline water when the flood comes. Hence the soil is not fit for purposes of cultivation but becomes a resort of a rich variety of fish. The dried fish which are carried on a Godhu, go by various names such as '*Badarer Chhuri*, *Ghoanrā*, *Phaisā*, *Laittā*, *Rishyā*, *Palkā*, *Chagaichhā*, etc.,

[1] They are called "Huri boats" in Maldwip and "Fatemari boats" in some places.

In April and March a large number of Godhus return to the Karnaphuli with their rich cargo of dried fish, and then it presents a spectacle which is never to be forgotten by the observer. The friends and relations of these fishermen who come back on their Godhus with the goods offer them a hearty reception, beating drums and tabors and playing on the shrill pipe, called the *Sanai* and the Karnaphuli becomes stirred all on a sudden with a dense concourse of people on her banks and with bristling activities of hundreds of Godhus, receiving a noisy ovation from the kith and kin of the enterprising fishermen. After the business-season of the Godhus is over, the parts are disjointed and kept in safe custody.

The construction of the Godhu is very simple. The keel is carved out of a long huge tree in the form of the crescent moon. Its breadth is very small. With this keel are jointed what the local people call *chāps*,—being pieces of timber not exactly like planks but concave-shaped thin wooden pieces, twenty to twenty five feet long, two or two and a half inches in thickness, and eighteen inches in breadth, which exactly fit in with the keel and with one and another. Nails are not used in joining the wooden pieces. Small holes called "*shama*" are made both ways and a strong kind of cane locally called "*gallāk*" is used for the purpose. The little space between two *chāps* are filled with straws of *ulu* species twisted like cords. They become so tight that not a particle of water can enter the boat though it is dashed by strong current. The *shamas* or the holes, after the cane has been made to enter through them, are filled up with jute, cotton and resin. The roofs of the Balam as well as the Godhu are called *pong*. The prow of the Godhu of old type was made

to look like the head of a crocodile. The boatmen used to adorn it with vermilion and floral wreaths.

3. The "Sloop" is like the Balam in many respects, changed into its present form by the influence of the Portuguese (Figs. III, IV, V, VI).

4. *The Sarenga.*—This kind of boat has lent its name to the Captain of a ship; a "*sareng*" means a Captain in the Bengali dialect. It is like a canoe, being carved out from a long tree, and there is no joining or patchwork in it. It seldom ventures on a sea-journey. Its scope of movement is limited to rivers.

5. *The Shampan.*—The shape of this class of boats is like that of a swan. It is a Chinese type with a slight variation, due to Burmese influence.

6. *The Kondha.*—It is made by carving out a huge tree of the Chittagong hills. If is carried with the help of bamboo-poles called the '*lagi*' and never travels in the sea. It hardly dares to face the turbulent waves of a river, having no sail or oar.

A new activity has been in evidence since 1916. Many ships have since been constructed in Chittagong in European style. The great war gave a stimulus to the activities of the Chittagong dockyards, and from the official reports of the ports we find that no less than forty ships were built by the Balamis during the period 1916-21. Mr. Williams and Lt. Wilson took great pains in teaching the Balamis to construct ships in approved scientific methods of the west. Inspite of the defects of the old style, Lt. Wilson was struck with the remarkable skill of the Balamis in ship-building. Their trained hands could build the whole and its parts, joining pieces of timber and going through other details with almost scientific precision, without making any plan or design beforehand. The Balamis belong to the Jogi caste

and are called Bāheriās, a local name indicating that the water touched by them may not be drunk by higher castes. This proves that they were probably Buddhists and did not believe in the restrictions imposed on us by later Hindu jurisprudence as regards sea-voyage. In olden times there were docks in Halisahar, Patenga, Doble Mobing and various other places on the Karnafuli. Fig. II shows the congestion of a great number of smaller boats at the Chāktai ghāt of Chittagong port.

At the present day Madhab, Kalikumar and Dwarika Nath have achieved distinction as ship-builders. Dwarika Nath is by far the best of the three men. Madhab is now engaged in building a steam-launch. He has nearly completed the wooden structure by timbers of the Chittagong Hill-tracts. The engine will be placed in due course. Most of the sloops and ships of which pictures are given in this book were constructed by Kali Kumar, and Dwarika Nath is now engaged in executing some orders for ships at Rangoon.

It may be interesting to note here the local names given to parts of a ship in the Chittagong dialect. They call the ship's 'Rib'—*bāk*, its Floor—*Kahana*, Keel—*erāk*, Keelson—*Shukankila*, Stern-post—*Gudasta*, Stem—*Rad*, Mast—*Mastul*, Rake of the mast—*Mastuler chaluta* and Batten—*Ishka*.

The famous 'Kosha' boats used to be made in the district of Dacca. We have got an exaggerated description of Kosha in the ballad of Isha Khan.

In conclusion I beg to offer my thanks to Mr. Jogesh Chandra Chakravartty, M.A., Assistant Registrar, Calcutta University, for making arrangements for the speedy publication of this volume. Dr. John Van Manen of the Asiatic Society of Bengal was kind enough to lend me two blocks containing pictures of cannon of Ishā

Khan and Sher Shaha published in the Journal of that Society for 1910. He has also kindly given me permission to reprint the picture of a cannon of the illustrious Moslem Chief of Jangalbari with a Bengali inscription also published in the Journal of the Society for 1910.

My thanks are due to Babu Biswapati Chaudhury, M.A.—the well-known Bengali writer and artist for the excellent pen and ink sketches that he has drawn of some of the characters described in the ballads of this volume. He did the work with the utmost quickness, though he was suffering at the time from ophthalmia—I am pleased with his work, though I am sorry he disregarded his health in his eagerness to finish the work in the shortest time.

My young friend, Mr. Janardan Chakrabartty, M.A., appointed by the Calcutta University to help me in the compilation of the ballads, rendered me some service in March last when owing to my hard and unsparing labour in connection with the ballads I fell seriously ill. Mr. Chakrabartty translated small portions of the Bengali texts into English for me in that month.

My friend Miss Rowlands, B.A., Lady Principal of the Darjeeling Missionary College, was kind enough to revise a portion of my translations.

Munshi Jasimuddin, one of our ballad collectors, has supplied photographs of the old capital of Laksman Hazra, now reduced to a swamp and of the ruins of the palace and the mosque built by the immediate descendants of Ishā Khan.

Inspite of my great labour in connection with the ballads I am sorry to say that there are many errors in the book. I do not blame anybody but myself for this fault. I am not at all a good proof-reader,

And though I have been writing books for these forty years, I have not at all improved in this direction. This makes me believe in the saying that a proof-reader is born and not made.

7, Biswakosh Lane,
Bagbazar. Calcutta:
The 15th July, 1926.

DINESH CHANDRA SEN.

THE LOVE OF THE WASHER-MAIDEN

PREFACE

The song of the Washer-maiden is one of the typical love-ballads of Eastern Bengal, rich in the musical rhythm of its limpid verses and in the mystic suggestions of its all-absorbing and resigned surrender of self.

The maiden Kanchanmala, a low-caste handsome girl, receives attention from the young prince of her native city. While feeling in her heart romantic sentiments, verging on worship, she knows full well the difference between her own social status and that of the prince. She is, therefore, full of hesitancy in the beginning. The gay light-hearted young prince once passionately seizes her by the hand, when she is all alone on the landing steps of a tank. She is surprised, she is pleased. She struggles to free herself, she makes false promises and trembles in fear. But all in vain. Her mind is filled with his image; she is almost frenzied by the sweet attraction. All the struggle on her part, however, is set at rest by the bold ways of the prince, who takes a vow to court any danger for her sake and speaks many things which one says to another, when Cupid, for the first time, aims his dart at young hearts. The poet describes, with great power, the aggressions of a self-willed capricious but loving youth on her modesty, on the one hand, and the timorous approaches of the maiden, afraid of scandal, and nervously conscious of her low status, on the other. Then, when in the language of worldly men she has actually sinned, she stops with a sigh to reflect, when she sees the Khorāi flowing by, "Whence dost thou come, O stream, and knowing not whither thou wilt go, why art thou in such a mad hurry?" (Canto III,

Lines 1-2). This little speech indicates an anxious thought about her own mad course and uncertain future.

Here we find her, indulging in reveries, which, shrouded in obscure and suggestive poetry, verge on mysticism. She has loved one, whom neither heaven nor earth meant for her. Providence has made him high and her low. He is a treasure, too big for her heaven and too great for her little world. Neither heaven nor earth will sanction her so great a gift. But what of that? She cannot now give up what, in the estimation of the world, she is not justified to possess, though she obtained the treasure by sheer chance. This is indicated by her mystic reflections (Canto III, Lines 3-6). Often when the prince sleeps on a bed of leaves, she sighs to think that for her poor sake, he has left his golden couches and laid himself so low. When they pass the whole night without a wink of sleep, she feels a pain in her heart to see that the prince is compelled to forego the sweet attractions of rest and go away, with eyes heavy-laden with sleep, at the break of the dawn. (Canto III, Lines 7-10).

The prince treacherously abandons her. She is stunned by the blow. She cannot speak out her grief to others, for they have been already condemning her conduct as stupidly bold. She speaks her sorrows to the river, to the boats and to the trees. It is mute Nature to whom the mute soul finds a solace in appealing. (Canto IX, Lines 35-38.)

Sometimes she madly thinks that he may yet come. She has not yet obtained any proof of his treachery. She is elated by the foolish hope that he may return to her, full of love, and with gifts for her. "He will bring with him ornaments, studded with diamonds and pearls and I will pay the price with two drops of my tears." (Canto IX, Lines 40-42).

But when twelve months and thirteen days passed, from the day of his leaving her, "she blows out the candle of her room with her own breath and creeps into the dark to hide herself." (Canto IX, Lines 32-34.)

It is from the time of the departure of the prince that Kanchan rises to the majesty of a sublime character and becomes the true heroine of the ballad. The pathos of her last appeal to the inanimate objects of Nature shows her intense desire to hide herself from the world, particularly from the prince. He is happy with Rukmini, the princess. She is sincerely afraid, lest that happiness be disturbed. She puts her finger to her lips, enjoining silence. She sees the spot, where she used to make a bed of leaves for him, she remembers how they made garlands of flowers for each other and how, in the depth of night, she used to run away from home at a signal from his flute. She prays that all this may be blotted out from the memory of the prince, lest these should cause him pain. The river will be her silent grave. She prays to her that "not even the little tailor-bird, that drinks a sip from her water, might know of her death." (Canto XIII, 31-32.)

Secretly she has suffered; let her secretly pass away, leaving no sign behind, to cause pain to the prince, whom she found happy, with his new consort, the day before. She asks the waves "to carry her with them, floating into the boundless unknown." (Canto XIII, 47-48.)

One of the striking features of these rustic song-makers is a sense of decency, that pervades their poems. I believe that it is the court-poets who, in the medieval age, used to prostitute their genius by pandering to the erotic humour of princes and potentates—their patrons. The rustic mind breathes a purer moral air, just as these country people enjoy a freer air in the physical world.

We find in these poems situations which give great opportunities to the bards for revelling in indecency, but they instinctively know how far they should proceed and where they should stop. Everyone will admit that the poems override all conventions and canons of conservatism and orthodoxy. They are fresh and vigorous, with Nature's strength; but there is caution in their guarded language, proving their plain life to be a fountain of all that is wholesome and noble. These lyrical poems show the heart of the peasant, sweet as a field-flower and full of flavour as the fruits he grows in his garden.

Of the characters, next to the heroine, is the hero in importance. In these ballads the hero is generally less heroic than the heroine and more or less serves the purpose of a background. We have found several cases, where the hero has taken more wives than one. The custom of the country favoured this practice, and though the extraordinary man may always rise above the level of average people, we cannot condemn a person for yielding to a prevailing social custom. But the prince here is not only weak but treacherous. He takes no notice of a simple-minded and loving village woman, whom he has ruined with high promises.

The poet cleverly introduces many situations with an admirable artistic skill. Tamsā Gazi's description of the old washerman in the concluding part of the account of his interesting travel, undoubtedly creates a new situation. So does the love-letter of princess Rukmini. The plot is formed by a quick succession of well conceived array of incidents, which invest the poem with all the sweetness and effect of a superior melo drama.

The Song of the Washer-maiden was collected by Chandra Kumar from several sources. He owes the main portion of it to one Babu Rajanikanta Bhadra of the village

Shakuāi Bāttā in the district of Mymensingh. Of the rest a part was secured, on his way home from that village, from a milkman named Dinagopa of Char Sambhugunj. An old man of Kirtankhola, who is known by the name of *Madhur Bāp* (father of Madhu), added some songs and the remaining portion he got from Kulpur, Sankāṇḍā, and the neighbouring localities. He sent the ballad to me on the 15th of November, 1924.

The ballad contains 469 lines. I have divided it into 13 cantos. We can give no definite information as regards the time when the ballad was composed, nor any clue as to who its author was. Judging from the language and the spirit of the songs, I believe it to belong to that age when the country-people delighted in topics, showing absolute freedom in love. We have it on the authority of Chandidās that during his times love by mutual selection, untrammelled by, and triumphing over, all social barriers, was favoured by young men, and that many of them fell victims at the altar of the presiding deity of Sahajiya-love.

The lyrical element, the brevity and compactness of the plot, the never-failing relevancy of the topics and the dramatic character of the incidents, described in the poem, indicate that it is one of the oldest ballads that have been brought in to our possession; for, the later the age of composition, the more verbose and pedantic are the verses. The later ballads, besides, often deviate from the main subject in order to pander to some conventional forms or the need for propaganda. The freshness of country-life breathed in this poem, belongs to an age, when Chandidās, the gay bard of Nanoor, sang his immortal songs. Indeed this ballad has so many lines, to be found almost *verbatim* in Chandidās' poetry that we are inclined to suggest a common age for both. There are many points

in Chandidās' poems for which no precedent is to be found in classical Sanskrit poetry. The sports of Krishna with the *Gopis* on a ferry-boat, and a hundred other manœvres with which the divine lover seeks the favour of the beauteous milk-maid of Jabat are not to be found in any earlier Sanskrit poem. They have no doubt been incorporated into the love tales of Rādhā-Krishna being gleaned from materials, supplied by ballads like these. This pastoral country was once full of love-tales, of which a refined ideal was conceived and developed in the country-side and subsequently spiritualised in the Vaishnava poems; and our old rural ballads had already perfected a felicitous language of emotion, which became familiar throughout the province and latterly served as a tool in the hands of the Vaishnavas. It is for this reason that many common lines occur in the poems of the Vaishnava poets and in these ballads. The latter point to an age, when Bengal,—a rural country, resonant with the sound of the cowherd's reed-flute and warblings of a thousand singing bards, the land of sweet pastoral occupations and of murmuring rivers and swamps, overgrown with lotuses and screw-plants was, so to speak, Love's own resort. The people were free from the struggles of life owing to the rich fertility of the soil and indulged in songs, of which the one theme was love.

What the age of the poem is I cannot definitely say, but it is one of the sweetest love-poems in our language and both by the testimony of its language and the freedom from all conventions, it seems to me, as I have already said, to be one of the earliest of the ballads that we have yet come across. I shall not be surprised if some contemporary evidence proves it beyond all doubt to be a production of the 14th century.

25th March, 1925. D. C. S.

The Love of the Washer-maiden.

Chorus—The pain of separation burns me like a flame. I loved but not a day have I been happy.

(1)

Kānchanmālā.

"The Champa-flowers have bloomed on all sides of this beautiful tank. Let me off, my love, I will comb my hair and adorn it with these.

"A soft bed of leaves have I prepared on the side of the tank. There, my love come in the night, and in night, depart. For God's sake, friend! do not visit me in day-time.

"The neighbours delight in spreading scandal. Cruel are they. They would do nothing else, if they find a topic for scandal. If they see us together at such an hour, they will speak unkind things of us.

"My father and mother live in the house. How shall I explain my conduct to them? The topic of our love will be like a rich feast to the village folk at our cost.

"Leave my hands, my beloved. Allow me to go home. I cannot tarry more. Just see, my pitcher is going to be drifted away by the stream.

"From yonder banana-groves, give me the signal by your flute in the night and we shall meet there when it will be dark."

The Prince.

"It is evening. You are going alone to fill your pitcher. Stand for a moment, so that I may exchange a word with you.

"Your long flowing curly hair has come down to your knees. Youth has given you new charms and a fullness of limbs. I will speak to you for a little while. Give me a hearing, dear maiden. Your eyes are blue and dark like the *aparājitā*-flower and your tender body bears all the glow of the *champā*. Know, fair maiden, that it is the beauty of your curly hair, above all, that has driven me mad.

"I will ask of my father his kingdom and riches, and these will be my dowry to you at our marriage.

"Like the bird *Chil*, that hovers high in the air, my mind wanders forth day and night in the region of fancy delighting in your love.

"Stand a little longer and listen to my words, which come from the heart and are sincere."

Kānchanmālā.

"Leave my hands beloved youth. I am but half-dead with shame. At day-time, if they see us together, ours will be a name of shame for ever.

"What will my father and mother say, if they hear a report of our love? Don't you remember that your parents are the sovereigns of this country and my father is your royal father's poor washerman and his humblest subject? All this you seem to have forgotten.

"You are like the Moon and high is your status. Why should you stretch your hands to reach this low earth? What will people say if they hear of this? You are like a golden bee, who should seek a lotus. It is not becoming of you to seek such humble ones as myself.

"Leave my hands and allow me to depart. Sober down your mind and act sensibly."

Prince.

"You wash my clothes, dear maiden, with tenderest care. I trace, with a sigh, the sign of your five soft



"Leave my hands, beloved youth." P. 10.

fingers on them. They bear the scent of flowers, you weave into a garland for me. I feel in my heart that you love me dearly.

"Now take the oath that in the night-time you will come to this spot with all the treasure of your youth, sweet as a blooming flower.

"Here on this spot shall I take my stand and signal you by my flute. Here on this spot shall I spread a bed of leaves for you and here on this spot, shall we spend the night together. Here will be realised all the dreams of my youth in your sweet company."

Kānchanmālā.

"How can I, my charming friend, give you the promise you want. My parents always stay at home. Now on my life, be gracious and accede to my request. Be pleased to leave my hands.

"True, there is a surging emotion, which overflows my heart, like a river, overflowing its bank in August. True my heart has run out of all control. When I sleep, I dream of your sweet face. That is all my happiness in this world. If Providence would give an opportunity, even this day, this hour, I would leave my parents for your sake. This is my oath. Sun and moon, be witness to it; and you, my chief witness, have heard what has fallen from my lips. Doubt not my sincerity." (Ll. 1-53.)

(2)

TIME—NIGHT.

Kānchan hums a tune in her room.

"My oath is broken, O prince. By no means can I come out. My parents I find awake each time I attempt to come out. My home seems to me strange and unwelcome, and the sides of the tank, sweet and familiar, and

dear as home. Fear of society and of what the people would say stand in my way.

"But what is this fear for society ? What do I care for honour ? For God's sake, young friend, do not sing any more that song with your flute. It makes me mad. It drives me like a storm, making me a slave to your wishes.

"But do not despair. Wait a little more. Sleep has just crept into the eyes of my parents. Erelong they will fall into deep sleep.

"Lo ! the black clouds are roaring in the sky. O, what a pity ! Providence, I fear, will not allow us to meet to-night.

"I hear the showers falling around. Pray my beloved, do not expose yourself to rain. The esculent plant *Mān* has spread its large leaves behind our house. Cut off one of these from the stalk and protect your head.

"Alas friend I imagine from here, your fair figure to be wet with rain. I am not near you in this depth of night. With what care would I not wipe away water from your body, brushing the drops with my flowing hair !"

TIME—MID-NIGHT.

Kānchanmālā.

"The whole world is asleep. A deep silence pervades all. Only the maddening flute sings that one tune. Now I am coming out of my house. Which is the path that I shall follow in this dark hour ?

"There is no cloud in the sky. The moon shines. If I go by this path at such an hour, I may be caught and exposed to shame.

"There is a tree, which has no branches and no leaves. It bears the treasure of one solitary flower. It is the tree

of love.* If I get my beloved near me, what do I care for society, its praise and protection ? " (Ll. 1-20.)

(3)

PLACE—RIVER-BANK.

Kānchanmālā.

" O River, which way dost thou follow ? Whence hast thou come and whither art thou bound? Without knowing thy destination, thou seemest, in a mad hurry to go.

" The morning is golden. In the sky wander forth the dispersed clouds. What is this bird that has come down from the sky with its golden wings ? If the bird is to be given a space in this Earth, it seems that the Earth is too small for it. If it flies up neither does it find space there that can hold it. Where may I find a cage to keep thee O bird of my heart ? How can I keep thee, and where ?" †

* * * *

" My beloved has gone away in the morning. Why did the blessed night pass away ? I was with him for the whole night.

" Ah a moment he could not sleep in the night (gaily talking with me) ! His eyelids were heavy with sleep in the morning. Yet he had to depart in all haste !

" Ever accustomed to sleep on a stately couch, he made the bare ground his bed for my sake !

* The tree of Love does not give protection as society does, but still it has the power to charm the soul, (that is its one flower).

† She is filled with the idea that she has loved one whe is too high for her. There is no space, here below in society, none in heaven either, where this love may have a sanction and a place assigned to it.

"When one, in his position, loves a woman of low birth, one becomes the subject of ridicule of all. And this he will have to suffer for my sake!

"I am like the dwarf, aspiring to catch the Moon. Alas, why have I taken this mad course? You seek an answer? I myself do not know, why! My mind has lost all control.

"O my pitcher, sink here in this water, like a drop (no path for escape will you see). I am lost like you in the boundless sea by loving him. Here is the pitcher; I have raised it again from the water. But who will raise me from the sea into which I have been drowned? People whisper all kind of things when they see me. Fain would I tie this pitcher with a rope around my neck and drown myself for the sake of my love. If you come to night, my beloved, I will keep a box of betels, ready for you. I will place at your feet, my youth, my life, my honour and my all! I will leave my parents and my home and seek a shelter in the forest." (Ll. 1-28.)

(4)

The Reporter.

"O lord, your son has been addicted to a washer-woman and become mad for her love. Your Highness seems to be unaware of this fact. He is your own washerman and his daughter washes the clothes of the palace. For such a wretch has the prince run mad. Her name is Kānchan. Her colour is bright and fair. Your son has fallen into her snares. The union is like that of the Moon and the demon Rāhu. It is all the work of that wicked and treacherous old washerman."

The king burnt with rage and looked like flaming fire at this report and commanded the washerman to be brought to his presence at once.

On his shoulders was a bundle of washed clothes and on his hand, he carried a staff. Godhā, the washerman, came trembling to the rich one's mansion.

The Raja was holding his *durbar*, surrounded by his courtiers and body-guards. Godhā folded his palms before his lordship and delivered himself thus :—

"For two days, there have been incessant rain and storm, and the Sun did not even peep into our lands. I could not dry the clothes, O mighty lord, for this reason there has been a delay."

The Raja was trembling in rage, for a time, his voice was choked and then he angrily spoke to the miscreant Godhā thus :—

"Your daughter has come of age and you have not yet given her in marriage. My son, I hear, has taken a fancy to her. If, by to-night, you do not marry her to some one, my constables will go in the morning and bring her to the palace forcibly, dragging her by her locks through the public streets."

Godhā.

"At the dawn of day, to-morrow, I will marry her to Bāguā, the gardener, who works as day-labourer in this town."

Resting the weight of his person on his staff, the old man slowly approached his home. For the whole night the washerman and his wife had not a wink of sleep and cried in bitter grief.

But where is the Prince gone and where is Kānchanmālā? The drums beat through the streets, announcing reward for their arrest. Here ends a chapter of the song. (Ll. 1-30.)

(5)

A Meadow Land.

Kānchanmālā.

"Helpless woman that I am, I cannot see the path in darkness. I am unfamiliar with this place. Look how beautifully the flowers of the screw-plant have bloomed on the bank of yonder river. Clasp me by my hand, my beloved, and take me there. I cannot walk any further. My limbs seem heavy. I cannot carry them any further. Wait, dear love, let us sleep here and take rest for the remaining hours of the night."

The Prince.

"Fair maiden, do not stop here. We must go a little further and cross the jurisdiction of the King, my father.

"Streaks of light seem to issue from the East. I think, it will be dawn erelong.

"Let us go, seeking shelter at the abode of some well-to-do householder. If we fail in this, we shall have to wander about in this forest like two banished souls. There, in your sweet company, shall I walk in the jungle, and when we shall feel hungry, the fruits of the wilderness will appease our hunger. Under the shade of trees, we will spread leaves, and this will be our bed, and the tiger and buffaloes will be our kindred."

Kānchanmālā.

"The night, my friend, seems wellnigh over. The last struggling moonbeams have spread a sparkle on the western sky. I think, we have crossed the jurisdiction of your father, the King.

"My father will mourn my loss in the morning and my mother will strike her head against the wall for

grief. You have left your great palace and I have given up all considerations of society and family-life. Though tender by nature, being a woman, I have become hard as stone.

"See the day is dawning over the fair world. But no more shall we see the dear landing-ghat of the Khorāi and no more those fair fields, filled with the golden *sāli*-harvest! The night is taking leave, but no more shall we see our home, our good neighbours, our kinsmen—men and women amongst whom we have lived so long! When the night will pass, no more shall we hear the gay songs of the birds of our Motherland, nor see that sky of morning, through scenes so familiar to the eyes. Alas, the fair flowers of our garden! Never more will they bloom for us. For our whole life have we separated ourselves from the society of our friends and kinsmen."

The Prince.

"Weep not, fair maiden, grieve no more. Henceforward shall we have no home but become dwellers of the forest.

"Weep no more, fair maiden, set your mind at ease. We, two, like two flowers, are strung garland-like, by fate.

"What is that the people are speaking there on the bank of the river? Whose jurisdiction may this be and what is the country called?" (Ll. 1-36.)

(6)

THEY MEET A WASHERMAN.

The Prince.

"Listen to me, O washerman, you are surely a servant of the Raja and wash the clothes of the palace. Can

you give a lodging to us two? I have fallen in evil times and my companion is greatly suffering from fatigue. My father has driven us both away. We had to leave home in extreme sorrow."

The washerman, with his eyes wide-open, gazed at them. One looked like the sun and the other like the moon,—both of them as if fallen from the sky. He wonderingly eyed them from head to foot, and overpowered by emotion, could not speak for a time. He took them for a prince and a princess.

The Washerman.

"I have no son, no daughter. You be my children. Come and live with me. My wife Aduna will be a mother unto you. You two will rule my house, like the angels, presiding over its fortune. I earn my livelihood by washing the clothes of the Rājā's palace."

The Prince.

"I take you for my foster-father. Know me to be the son of a washerman. I will wash the clothes of the palace for you. I know how to do that. Your household work will be done by this maiden. We shall be like children unto you, and you like our father. We will stay at your house, so long as we live." (Ll. 1-19.)

(7)

Princess Rukmini.

"How is it that the clothes have been washed so well this time? Never did the old man show such cleverness before."

The maid-servant came to Rukmini and said :—

"A young washerman has come, it is he that washes your clothes. He is handsome and bright as the moon

and looks like a prince in disguise. With him there is a maiden, whose beauty is wonderful. Her hair falls on her back with many a lovely curl, and her colour is of the *Atasi*-flower or like molten gold. Youth has just dawned on her. She is a wonderful thing to behold."

On having the report, Rukmini, the princess, sent for the washerwoman.

The Princess.

"My maid-servant has given me strange news. I hear you have a daughter and a son-in-law by chance. This maiden, who has brought our clothes to-day to my apartment is young and handsome. I should like to make friends with her."

Days passed, and Kānchanmālā paid her visits to the princess often. The latter liked her for her beauty and became greatly attached to her. How often did they embrace each other, declaring sincere friendship! They opened their heart freely in conversation, and three months passed in this way. (Ll. 1-22.)

(8)

One day Rukmini said to her friend :—

"Where is your home? Who are your parents? Why have you come to this city and where do you intend to go afterwards? How is it that you have left your parents and home, and for what fault? The young man, your companion, is exceedingly handsome. Has he brought you here by force, or was it love for him, which made you give up home-connections and choose this life of an exile? Tell me, dear friend, your whole history, without hiding anything from me."

Kānchanmālā, a girl known for her self-control and prudence, in an evil moment, lost both, and related to the princess her whole story.

The Princess, alone.

"This youth, so handsome, comes often to the palace. It is not fit that he should do the mean work of a washerman. He is not so by birth. He is a prince. It is his evil luck that has doomed him to this life of sorrow. When he comes to the palace with clothes, my thirsty eyes gaze at him through the window. Ah, my bee! Your place should be in the bosom of a lotus. You have turned to be a worm of dung. This daughter of a washerman has reduced you to this plight, turning your head by her wily love. The princess, otherwise so good and sober, yielded to a weakness in an evil moment and sent a letter covertly through the clothes to the youth."

Letter.

"O my love, I do not know who you are. Your handsome figure has charmed me. You are the play of evil stars and have given a false report of yourself to my father, the King. Like the bee, you are a wanderer in the garden, now enjoying yourself lightly over stray flowers.

"The month of April is in sight. The spring has already entered into Nature's fair fields. The cuckoo's gay notes are heard everywhere and the flowers show their full bloom. The women of the city are gaily playing with the red powder *ābir*. Is it the season to come to the inner apartments of the Raja with a load of clothes on the head? Fie! If I could find you for a moment to speak to you in private, I could open my heart freely. Now you may know the pain of Rukmini's heart from this letter, which I cannot make too plain." (Ll. 1-32.)

(9)

O man, inconstant and fickle like the bee, leaving the faded flower and running to a fresh one ! Untrustworthy and treacherous is your heart !

One day the prince said to Kānchanmālā, " Permit me leave for three months. Remain here in this washerman's house. I want to travel abroad. After three months, I will meet you again."

She did not suspect anything, she dreamt nothing foul. Her simple soul took the matter lightly and she complied with her lover's request in all sincerity.

Three months passed. In the city was heard the sound of drums. There were great merry-makings, festivities and rejoicings in the king's mansion. Kānchan asked Adunā, her foster-mother, " What is all this festivity, mother, in the palace, for ? Why are the drums beaten and why do the pipes sound ? "

Adunā returned from the palace and said. " A prince from an unknown country has come to marry Rukmini."

These three months he has gone—the fourth is passing ; yet he has not returned. It is the fifth month now, but poor Kānchan still hoped that he would return. In the sixth month, she lost all taste for food, and passed her nights, troubled with dreams. In the seventh she could not close her eyes for a moment in sleep. In the ninth, she began to feel those pangs of the heart, which, like worms eating into the green bamboos, sap the vitality of youthful lovers. She now gave up the last hope. In the tenth month, like unto the arithmetical figure ten, a cipher was put against her luck. In the eleventh month, Kānchan tried to compose her mind knowing for certain that she was doomed to lasting sorrow. On the night of the thirteenth day after the

lapse of full twelve months, she blew out the candle of her room with her own breath and wept, creeping into the dark, which she now liked better than light.

She wandered about the bank of the river and cried alone. She addressed the river and said, " I know not whence you have come, O river, and whither you are bound? Perchance you may meet him. And if you ever do so, kindly remind him of me. Ye boats, that come from afar with sails unfurled, does any of your crew know anything of my beloved and can he give me any tidings of him? You have wandered across rivers and through the deep and visited many a land. Did you not come across any place, from which you could get any message about the treasure I have lost?

" O happy day when he will return and bring for me, prince as he is, ornaments studded with diamonds and pearls. Alas, poor as I am, I will accept them from him paying two drops of tears as their price.

" To-day has also past. My hope will rest on the morrow, and when to-morrow will pass, I will place my hope on the day after. Thus will my life end. O my friend, O my love, I was doomed to sorrow by fate and bear a life of scorn for ever." (Ll. 1-44.)

(10)

The Collector of revenues of the Rājā called the washerman, one day, to his presence and said to him in private in a menacing tone, " In your house lives a young maiden. I will pay you for her Rs. 500 in cash, besides a new house and lands with it. You know my power. The calf dies in the womb of a cow, if I give it an angry look. If you do not agree, know it for certain that you will be a ruined man in no time. You are to send her immediately to me."

The washerman returned home and told everything to his wife Adunā and added. "The Collector will ruin me. My house and things will be burnt down. Why should we suffer all these for one, who is nobody to us?"

Adunā to Kānchan.

"O beautiful one, listen to my advice. You have now spent a whole year with us. You are a virtuous girl and I am like your mother. On my life, I ask you to promise me one thing. You will leave our house this very night. The wicked Collector has turned our enemy. Somehow or other, he has seen you in our house. If you stay here any more, we are sure to be the victims of his ire. Our life will be at stake. Our house and things will be burnt to ashes. Now my advice to you is this. Be the true woman that you are and leave our house at once, to save yourself and us from the danger that hangs overhead." (Ll. 1-20.)

(11)

In a village, called Pirer Kānda, lived Tamsā Gāzi, a wholesale trader in rice. He had five ships, with which he used to go abroad, for purchasing rice. He was coming from northern districts, having purchased a large quantity of rice and got them husked there. His five ships were moored on the bank of the river 'Khorāi'; and one of his partners reported to him that a beautiful woman was crying on the river-bank.

Tamsā Gāzi had no child in his house. He had grown old and had no hope of getting any, in the future. He felt compassion for Kānchan and brought her to his home.

At the house of the Gāzi, Kānchan began to do all household duties. When she sat to cook her own meals, incessant tears fell from her eyes. When she dusted the floor, the ground became wet with her tears. She went with the pitcher to bring water from the river There her tears looked like a garland without string. The Gāzi and his wife showed her tender affection but could not guess at the cause of her sorrow.

The Gāzi.

"I am bound on a tour for trade. Tell me what I shall bring for you, dear daughter, you are now a child to us. We had no child to adorn our house. By the grace of God, we have got one in you."

As she heard him speak, she began to cry. "What should I ask of him?" she thought, "I have no desire for anything."

She could not say, for shame, what she wanted with all the longings of her soul.

Three months and thirteen days passed. The Gāzi has returned with many valuable goods. He has brought a pearl-necklace of rare value for Kānchan and a box, full of shell-flowerets to adorn her hair. He has, besides, brought a *sari* for her, of the colour of flame, a belt of beautiful pendants and ornaments for feet and nose. He has brought for her a bee-hive from the forest, full of sweet honey. In a basket he has brought dried fish and other articles of food. His boats are, in fact, stored with many edibles and articles of luxury.

The Gāzi is giving an account of voyage to his wife in detail.

"I saw a country where people built their roofs with straw of the *ulu* species, and another strange country, where water is to be found on the tree-tops.*

* The cocoanut tree, the fruits of which contain sweet water inside.

"In another place, I found men cooking the meals and serving them too, and the women driving the plough in the fields. It is the latter who do the marketing there, and in the public streets and bazars, one may see women, flocking by hundreds. There I found buffaloes, grazing in pastures on river-banks and the deer drinking water from the fountains. I saw many hills and many strange lands, as I was touring in different districts. Through many a river did I pass—big rivers which overflowed their banks and many merchant-vessels tossed on them. I passed through the domains of many Rājās." Then followed other detailed descriptions. He concluded by saying, "In one place I saw a sight, which cannot be forgotten. It was the capital of a Rājā. I saw his big palace from afar; and close to the river-bank, I saw a washerman, busy with washing. He was advanced in years. His eyes looked dim, without much of sight left in them and he did not hear if any one spoke in a low voice. I took him for a deaf man. On enquiry I learnt that he did the washing for the palace, but so feeble had he grown that he took seven days to wash a single piece of cloth. I pitied his condition, and called him to me. He had no son or male heir he said; but he had then, a daughter, who absconded with her lover to his infinite sorrow and shame. She turned unchaste and left her poor parents for ever. He has lost his eyesight and power of hearing by constantly grieving over her. For he cannot forget his daughter for all she had done. At intervals, he stopped and resumed his work, and covering his eyes with his hands, cried at the recollection of the girl, broken down and thoroughly unmanned by grief. His condition excited my pity and has left a deep impression on my mind. If one has no son or daughter, it is far better.

One can bear it; but unbearable is it to suffer the loss of a born child.

When Kānchanmālā heard this, she began to cry aloud for her father.

Kānchan.

"Hear my sorrowful tale, O my foster-father. Take me immediately to my father. I am that woman for whom he grieves. I was born in the family of a washerman, but, as ill luck would have it, I lost my virtuous life, owing to my evil stars or to some acts of my prior birth, I do not know. You cannot conceive, what a smouldering fire I have suppressed all this time in my heart. An object of public scandal, I bear a life of great misery. In this country, I can hardly expect to get my heart soothed." (Ll. 1-77.)

(12)

KĀNCHAN COMES BACK TO HER FATHER'S HOUSE.

Kānchanmālā's Father.

"You fell a victim to evil desire, my daughter and made this house a place of shame. For you, though living, I have become like one dead. My life has been blasted owing to my evil luck. Where was it heard that the high ever loved the low with constancy? One climbs a tall tree, courting the chance of death by falling down. One who tries to place one's feet on the air, despising the ground that one treads, finds no support. And you have known it by the experience of your own life that though you may cut a portion of your heart for another, that one is not likely to be your own. One does not always get, in return, what one

gives, however great the sacrifice may be. The bee hums a tune of love and the flower cannot judge the depths of his sincerity at the outset. But the flower knows the truth, when the bee breaks his empty promise and flies to another. The cloud and the moon seem to be fast friends for a time. But the next moment the cloud darkens the moon. If one contracts love with a bad person, the end is sure to be bitter. Just see the teeth and the tongue. They seem to live together in amity, but the former scarcely lose an opportunity to bite the latter. O unfortunate one, without knowing all this, like a baby you put your hands into the fire. Owing to the fault of some unknown deed in a past life, you have now lost all happiness of life.

"Love, dear daughter, is a good thing. To some, it proves life-giving nectar; to others, mortal like poison. Who should seek that love, which brings in scandal and disgrace in its train? The collyrium that adorns the eyes becomes black ink, when placed in an ink-pot. Love, which should have adorned your life, has become like worm-wood, being placed on a wrong person."

The daughter clung to the neck of the father and cried aloud. They both shed tears over their sad lot. The people of that city, however, never knew that the washerman's daughter had returned. (Ll. 1-38.)

(13)

They thought that she was a mad woman and had come there from some distant country. Nobody could know or recognise her, as she had grown so emaciated. Like the spirit of the air, she is for a moment here and then disappears. Like a whirlwind that runs and carries the dust before it, she moves about the city without

staying at any spot for a minute. Here is she seen under the shade of a tree; but the moment after, there she wanders by the river-bank. She sometimes sings an unmeaning song or bursts into unmeaning laughter. At one moment, she sits quietly and at the next, she is seen weeping.

Kānchan in the Palace.

Princess Rukmini is seated on a couch in an inner apartment in the palace. Suddenly like a gust of wind, the mad woman of the street enters the Rājā's palace. She saw the prince, seated in the audience-hall, looking resplendent like the moon. People said, "Lo, there goes the mad woman by this path."

For a few months, she had wandered through the streets of the city in that way. But from the day she saw the prince and the princess Rukmini in the palace, Kānchan was seen no more.

The moon and the stars had fallen into the hands of the clouds and were sometimes allowed to peep through the sky, and were obscured a moment after. In the dark night, no path was visible. It was the month of August and the river Khorāi was full. Kānchanmālā, like the very spirit of emotion that she was, maddened by love, came running to the river-ghat. The clouds were roaring and the rain falling in large drops. She came running in that dark night to the banks of the Khorāi.

Kānchan.

"All my sorrows are gone, my hopes have been fulfilled to-day. I have seen his dear face, for a sight of which I was longing all these days. May you, beloved, live long with the new bride! May you for ever enjoy her sweet company! Do not, I pray you, recollect poor

unfortunate Kānchan. I bow a hundred times at your feet from here. The trace of the bed of green leaves, we used to make here, on this green bank of the river, may still be seen. But, dear friend, do not recollect the dreams we dreamt in those days. Do not, also, O my beloved, recollect how we once made garlands of flowers for each other here. In the depth of night, at a signal from your flute, I used to come running here. Do not remember those days. Blot out all memory of unfortunate Kānchan from your mind.

"O river, do not divulge the story of my death. Let not even the little tailor-bird, that drinks a sip from your water know of my death. O ye, trees of the river-side, I pray thee, do not give out the news of my death and I pray you, O moon and stars, do not give out the report of my death to my beloved, lest it should cause him pain. I bow to you, my father, from here. Your daughter's last request to you is :—Do not say to any one that I returned home.

"O wind, you are my sole friend; I will whisper to you the tale of my heart. You are the witness of all—of everything that happens by day and everything that happens by night. You are ever present in this world. The scandal about this unfortunate one is so widespread that even the beasts of the forest and the birds of the air have heard of it. Kindly do not disclose to any one that I returned home. Say not a word of my death to my beloved lest he should feel a pain in his heart. I am sure, my own people will not know that I am going to die here.

"O waves, from where have you come and whither are you bound for? Take me along with you, floating into the unknown regions of the sea from which I may never come back to these sad shores.

The stars grew dim at that deep and still hour of the night.

Kānchan threw herself into the river and was lost. (Ll. 1-50.)

THE END.

THE YOUNG HERDSMAN.

(The First Version).

PREFACE

The 'Mahishāl Bandhu' (Lit. 'the friend, in charge of buffaloes,' which I have rendered into a simpler form and called the Young Herdsman) was once very popular in the eastern parts of Mymensingh. Indeed the spirit of romance, pervading the song and its deep heart-stirring pathos have a great appeal. We annex two versions of the ballad. The first one ends where Sujāti, the beautiful bride of Dingādhar, is forcibly carried away by Meghuā, the merchant. The second one repeats the story told in the first, with some material points of difference and carries it to where Raja Fengu of Chittagong holds his Court and passes the sentence of death by impalement on Dingādhar.

Both the versions, of which texts are given in this volume, are evidently incomplete. Babu Chandra Kumar tried his best to secure the last portions but could not. I have not, however, lost all hopes of recovering them.

The reason why so popular a song is on the verge of running into oblivion will not be far to seek. Hindu orthodoxy must have tried to suppress it in later times, just as it did in the case of the ballad of Mahuā. The songs of Bheluā and of the Washer-Maiden, which are also published here, breathe the same air of free love and sexuel romance, which could not be evidently tolerated by the Brahminic school. Hence it is that though in subject-matter and in spirit, these ballads are essentially Hindu, describing tales of pure Hindu life, their singing is now restricted amongst Muhamadan rustics, and these once favourite songs of pastoral love are running out of fashion.

We may now easily find in these songs echoes of those tender emotions, which, in a later epoch, became the

distinctive characteristic of the Vaishnava school of poetry. Chronological data should not be used as tests for ascertaining the school, to which they belong. These songs, as we have said elsewhere, represent, whate ver the date of their composition may be, the prevailing features of a school of poetry that preceded the one of the melodious bards, who followed Chandidas and made Bengal "a nest of singing birds." The dashing courage of Sujāti, Bheluā and the washer-maiden Kanchan, the exquisite emotions that invest their nature with an indescribable sweetness, their idealistic renunciation and intensity of love and sufferings forebode the coming epoch of emotioned felicity, full of mystic import and spiritual love, which marked the Vaishnava lyrics. In fact in the literature of this rustic poetry, one sometimes comes across, though in a somewhat crude form, the very words and phrases, which have lent supreme interest to Vaishnava poetry. This shows that the essentials of Vaishnava emotional poetry were already in the air, and that the poets, like Chandidās, Jnāna Das and Govinda Das, derived much of their exquisite ideas and inspiration from the soil in which they were born. They only embellished them, whereas the ballad-makers gave them in their original crude form. This literature of the ballads has, therefore, shown us the link, which binds the old school with the new, proving the homogeneity of the Bengal aesthetic culture.

The two versions, as I have already stated, while founded on the same story and showing their likeness in the essentials of the plot, differ materially in respect of some of the details. The first version evidently bears the trace of an interpolator's hands. The story of the love of Dingādhar with the maiden Sujāti, of course, constitute the central plot of the ballad. But the first version

appends to the poem the early career of Dingādhar, which is not quite relevant to the point and also brings Balarām on the scene unnecessarily introducing ramifications to complicate the plot. It also shows a little pedantry in describing the beauty of Sujāti and gives, here and there, philosophical reflections, which do not fit in well with the spirit of the simple love-tale that it is. (Cantos I, L 36-40 and II, L 30-36.) But if the interpolator has handled the story and added to its length, it must be admitted to his credit that he is not an unbearable pedant like Abdul Karim of Galāchipā who has recast some of the historical ballads on Isa Khan and his descendants. The poet who has added some passages here seems to be also a rustic bard and gives his added tales with almost the same unvarnished simplicity that we find in the original poem. The second version has none of these superfluities, which have been unnecessarily engrafted upon the main story. Dingādhar is not afflicted here by the loss of his parents, nor is he embarrassed by his father's death and obliged to bear a galling servitude. The ballad-maker leaves no margin, even for the sake of humour, for the advent of Asharia Mandal on the scene. Had such a Shylock actually existed in the original ballad it would not be easy for a later recensionist to do away with it. Though we miss much of the humour and poetry of the added cantos, in the second version, yet we find in it a greater compactness, a keener eye to relevancy, and a homogeneity, which undoubtedly prove it to be the original ballad. It is a pity that the entire poem could not be secured. From the concluding lines of the second version, we are led to believe that Sujāti did some wonderful heroic act, which probably redeemed the fate of her lover and raised her to the status of a real heroine. But the reader's curiosity will be nipped in the bud on coming to the last passage

of the text, which closes abruptly, leaving the reader's imagination to grovel in the dark as to the fate of the lovers. One thing strikes me as somewhat anomalous in the second version. It is difficult to understand why Dingādhar married Maynā. But in some of the ballads and folk-tales, we have already found the hero of the tales taking more than one wife—a practice not at all condemned by the social ethics of the Asiatic races. It is hinted (by line 22, Canto 7) that Dingādhar had also married Sujāti. But as we have found the ballad in an incomplete form, we would not like to risk any further comment on the point.

The special charm of the song lies in its description of the dawn of love on the pair. The lines "লাজেতে হইল কন্যার রক্তজবা মুখ। পর্‌থম যৌবন কন্যার এই পর্‌থম সুখ॥" (Canto Lines) are exquisite—indicating, as they do, the precious experience of first youth—the first happiness in woman's bosom, which, without any sense of guilt, makes her shy, suffusing her face with red colour. Unlike all that is known of our girls, given to husbands at an age when they have no power to choose, here is the value of marriage, based on mutual selection, so beautifully emphasised in the line, "সব চেয়ে অধিক শীতল মনোবাঞ্ছার পতি" (Canto 4, Lines 95-96). "There can be no joy, greater in the mind of a bride, than that of getting a youth for her husband whom she has chosen for herself." Let the orthodox Pandits, who have curtailed all freedom of our womankind learn from this that they have no power over the minds of their victims, and let them feel the force of this free expression of the rustic mind, which quotes no other authority than that which nature has stamped on the human soul.

The integrity of the people finds illustrations throughout the narrative in the first version in a clear and forcible

manner. Balarām contracted a debt of five hundred rupees—"ধর্ম্ম সাক্ষী করি" by a mere oath in the name of Virtue, and though Ashāriā Mandal, the money-lender, is an exceedingly stingy and exacting man, he accepts this oath as a conclusive surety for the money he lends. Unless a people were extremely God-fearing and honest, such a Shylock as he would not be satisfied by a mere oath of this nature. Loans were not barred by limitation, nor were the pleas of insolvency urged in defence. For Dingādhar had no property which could be seized by the money-lender, Balarām. He came to recover the money, thirteen years after the death of the boy's father. So great was the fear in the popular mind of keeping a debt, contracted by one's father unliquidated, lest the father should visit hell, that Dingādhar was overcome with a great despair, when he found it impossible for him to satisfy the creditor. He went to Balarām and offered his services in the pasture-ground, so long as the debt might remain undischarged. Balarām agreed to the offer but stated that it would take him six years to clear the debt by serving in that capacity. "বড় দুখে ডিঙ্গাধরের হাসি আইল মুখে।" Six years' thraldom was no joke! It was a disaster to spend the most precious part of one's youth in such humiliating servitude. But Dingādhar was happy at the thought that his father's debt would at last be cleared, and forgetting all his distress, he smiled with a sense of relief. This smile illuminates the characteristic honesty of the Bengal peasantry of the olden days.

The picture of agricultural Bengal—the Bengal of marshes, swamps and large rivers—of rustic huts and large ships laden with merchandise, showing the great commercial activities of the people,—of purity of rustic life, and above all, of the sweet emotions of abiding love, which makes the mind ready for martyrdom and

great renunciation—is mirrored in this poem in all its true colours and vivid grandeur. At the same time, the autocratic, cruel and arbitrary nature of the men in power, which is proved in other ballads also, is in clear evidence here in the account of Fengu Raja of Chittagong and of the perfidious merchant Meghuā.

We cannot make any guess as to the time when this ballad was composed. The original might have been composed before the advent of the Mahomedans, as throughout this long poem, there is no mention of any Mahomedan men or women. The accounts show that the ballad belonged to a country ruled by the Hindus and inhabited by these people alone. The few Urdu words that have crept into the song were probably later interpolations. In most of the ballads, there are clear proofs of the existence of Mahomedan elements in the incidents described. But neither in the poem of Bheluā, nor in this one, there is anything suggesting such an element. The evidence of vocabulary is not important, since, in the course of recitation of the songs, through long generations, foreign words would inevitably find their way into the body of the songs. The ballads were generally sung by low-class Hindus, and also by Mahomedans. The present Mahomedan rustics, as I have said elsewhere, were mostly recruited from the Hindu community. It is no rare phenomenon to trace the modern Mahomedan singers, to be mostly the descendants of Hindu ancestors, who had originally composed or sung a particular ballad. Hence Persian and Arabic words gradually entered into these songs, in later times.

It appears that the story had some foundation on facts. Apart from the local geographical accounts, given in both the versions, which breathe an air of truth, the incidents of both practically agree in giving a villainous

character to Meghuā and in describing the vicissitudes in the lives of Dingādhar and Sujāti. It seems, therefore, that the story is to be traced to some unknown historical source of olden times, to which local bards gave colourings, according to their choice, introducing some new features and omitting or changing the old narrative in some points. But the characters, as originally conceived, have remained true to the old historic tradition, though the ballad-makers have recast the story from age to age.

The town of Singāpur and Rangchāpur, where some of the principal incidents are said to have taken place, and the canal Singakhali, on the bank of which stood the home of Dingādhar may be pointed on the maps of Mymensingh and of the neighbouring districts. It appears from the description that the merchants used to have commercial transactions with the Burmese by means of ships. They also went, far beyond the northern part of Mymensingh, to countries, inhabited by Gāros and Kukis. When in the first version, we find mention of the woman folk, taking lead in the traffic of the market and as fond of dried fish, we are naturally reminded of the Burmese. The "Kamoonir Desh" referred to in the second part, seems to be Kāmākhya or Prāgjyotishpur (Assam).

The description of a storm on the courses of the river Surmāi, given in the second version, is an animated and picturesque one. It is interesting to note that when a rustic poet describes a scene, he reproduces his impressions based on personal observation—without trying to remember, and mostly without any knowledge of, what the earlier poets wrote on the subject. It is for this reason that the account the poet gives here is so life-like and graphic. I quote an extract here, to single out, from the ballad, a passage of rare force of style. It brings a scene of solemn grandeur to the mind's eye.

"শিবের জটা পিঙ্গল মেঘ আকাশেতে খেলে।
কুন্দিয়া তুফান আসে দরিয়ার জলে॥
পাড় পর্ব্বত ভাঙ্গ্যা ঢেউ ফলকিয়া উঠিল।
কে জানে দুষ্‌মণ্‌ মেঘুয়া কইবা ভাইস্থা গেল॥
তের দাড়িএ ডাক দিয়া কইল মইষালেরে।
উজান ধরিতে দায় চল যাই ঘরে॥
কাঁড়াল ভাঙ্গিয়া যায় পালের ছিড়ে দড়ি।
সামলাইয়া রাখিতে নাও আর নাহি পারি॥"

The rural phraseology of the boatmen of the country-side, the words of East Bengal dialect, such as কাঁড়াল, কুন্দিয়া, ফল্‌কিয়া, etc., conjure up a scene of wild storm, which are now and then witnessed on the big rivers of Eastern Bengal.

Chandra Kumar De was informed, about the middle of January, 1923, that the Ballad of the Herdsman was known to one Golak Viswas of Gopalgrām. By the last week of October, he collected the first version from three persons, *viz.* (1) Chandra Kumar Sarkar of Sutrakona (P. O., Fatehpur), (2) Kullār Abbās, a Mahomedan cart-driver of Rayer Bazar and (3) Nidhu Byapari a jute-merchant of the village Sohāgi. Hs sent me the first version on the 7th of November, 1923. He got information about a second from one Mahesh Ch. Sarkar of the village Māydulā and secured it from three sources:— (1) Gayā, a Namasudra by caste a native of the village Uchhigrām (Perg. Bhowal), (2) Mahajia Shaik, a Mahomedan of the same village and (3) Gāchhuni Shaik, a Mahomedan peasant of the village Kātgharā. Babu Chandra Kumar sent me this poem on the 7th of January, 1924.

The first version contains 494 lines and the second version 346 lines.

It is probable that the whole ballad may be secured from Jagaddal, a village in the Kishoregunj Subdivision of the district of Mymensingh.

3. 5. 12. D. C. SEN.

The Young Herdsman

(1)

There flows the river Singākhāli, whose greedy waves devoured the crops on her bend, last October. Here dwelt once an honest householder, whose story I am going to relate to you to-day.

He tilled thirteen *ārāhs* of land with the help of his buffaloes and every season he stored his granaries with rice of fine quality. He had an only son, fair and bright as the full moon. The parents endearingly called him by the name of Dingādhar or Master of the ships. In his tenth year, when, a mere lad, he whistled and wandered about the village-paths with a gladsome heart. His mother died suddenly. Other calamities also overtook the house. The large house of his father, divided into three spacious compartments, caught fire and was burnt to ashes. It seemed that the goddess of luck deserted the family. The buffaloes in the pastures and the cows in the sheds died of infectious diseases and the flood of October * washed away the ripecrops on the banks of the Singākhāli. None was there to sympathise with them in their distress. The old man had not a *cowrie* left to him and he was at his wit's end as to how he would find means to plough his lands on the river-bend.

After much hard and oppressing thought, he at last made up his mind. And one day, carrying a small bundle of some fried rice, as provision for his journey,

* I have roughly given English names for the corresponding Bengali months.

he set out for the city of Singapur. There lived a rich money-lender named Balarām, who used to lend money to the needy people on interest. He had become well off by this avocation. Thirteen festivities he performed during the twelve months of the year, especially the Doorgā Pujā with great éclat. In the month of November, he worshipped the god Kārtikeya, and in December, he performed the Puja of the harvest-goddess Lakshmi, with offerings of the new rice of the season. He was, in fact, a very prince among the peasantry of the village. Dingādhar's old father applied for help to this money-lender. He said, "I am in great distress, my lord. My fertile lands, which yield golden crops each season, are lying fallow. I have no plough, no bull. If you kindly lend me some money, regularly shall I pay you the interest. This help will save me from ruin."

He got a loan of Rs. 100, and after executing a bond, returned home with a cheerful heart. He now built one or two houses as the old ones had been burnt down and bought a pair of buffaloes for ploughing the fields. In the month of March, he tilled the land and sowed seeds. April and May rolled by. In June his rice was ripe, but just when he had begun to reap the harvest, the poor man caught fever and suddenly died. This is the course of this world. When after many days' hopes, the prospect of fulfilment comes, alas, one is taken off from his scene of action, showing how frail are human expectations. (Ll. 1-44.)

(2)

Dingādhar, the young lad, lamented wildly. "Alas," said he, "My mother died only the other day and you, my father, you, too, have left me thus! Who is there now

to look after me? I have no friend, no kinsman in this village, on whose help I may count." The neighbours came and said, "No one lives with his parents for ever" and spoke many a word of sweet consolation, but he would not be consoled. Again and again he cried and said, "Alas, who will now help me? I am utterly helpless, and an orphan in the fullest sense of the word."

He sold the buffaloes and performed the funeral rites of his father with the money. Thirteen years he lived in his village, earning his bread, with difficulty, by stray occupations. He was a mere child when his father died, and knew nothing of the debt his father had contracted. All on a sudden, after thirteen long years, Balarām, the money-lender, paid him a visit and said, "Your father was a good man with a religious turn of mind. He was a man of character. I was extremely pained at the news of his death." He then produced the document and said that falling into distress, Dingādhar's father had taken a loan of hundred rupees from him. "Here is the document," he said, "and all the people of our village know about this loan. Now tell me if you are willing to pay your father's debt."

As if a thunderbolt had fallen on Dingādhar's head! He prayed for two months' time, which Balarām readily granted.

Dingādhar now wept day and night, without being able to devise means to pay the money on the promised day. The scriptures say, if a man dies without clearing his debt, he finds no place in heaven but straightway goes to hell. If such a man is reborn in this earth as a tree, the loan pursues him as a wild creeper and holds him tight in its grip, giving him no rest. No escape there is from the hands of the man, to whom one *is in* debt. The pursuit goes on through all future lives.

Often the debtor is born as a bull and drives the plough on his creditor's rice-fields. Loan is worse than fever or headache. Its pain increases day by day. The money-lenders are, as a class, heartless. They do not remit a single *cowrie* of interest. Just as a man, passing by a bee-hive and stung by the bees, becomes mad with pain, even so is the debtor, and he considers the pain of debt the worst of all other ills of life.

His father, before his death, had disposed of most of his lands, hard pressed by want. His houses were now at the point of crumbling down, the roofs out of repair and the posts in a half-shattered condition. The buffaloes were sold long ago to meet the expenses of the father's *sradh*. How could he now clear the debt, swollen into a large amount with interest? What would Dingādhar do under the circumstances? Seeing no way out from his growing anxieties, he left his home and went to Singāpur and one afternoon presented himself before Balarām. (Ll. 1-40.)

(3)

Dingādhar had not bathed, nor had he any meals that day. In great distress he appeared before the money-lender. He found Balarām, seated in his out-house, and approaching him, humbly laid his hands upon his creditor's feet and said, "I have come to clear my father's debt—if only you would kindly help me to do so. A father's debt is the son's; and I do not wish to shirk my responsibility." Balarām was moved. He said, "What amount have you brought with you, my child? Let me find out what the dues are, from the account? Give me the sum I lent. I will not charge any interest."

Dingādhar stretched forth his empty hands and began to cry. "Just see," he said, "I have nothing with me. I am a beggar. Know me to be your slave. I have come with great hopes. Kindly engage me as a servant in this house and thus release me from my father's debt."

Then Balarām thought over the matter for a while and said, "I have need of a young servant. All right. I give you the charge of my buffaloes. If you can do this work for six years, I will release you from your father's debt and tear off the bond."

Though distressed to think of his long years of servitude, a smile still broke upon the lips of young Dingādhar at the thought that he would at last be able to clear his father's debt at a future time. (Ll. 1-20.)

(4)

Let us, for a time, pass from the topic of Balarām and Dingādhar to that of the maiden Sujāti.

Balarām had a youthful daughter in his house, beautiful as the evening-star. She looked like the very lamp of the house and spread a halo of light around like the moonbeams. The crow is dark, the cuckoo, a shade darker. And darker still is the water of the river Singākhāli. But the fine hair of the damsel was praised as the darkest of them all. Her figure was symmetrical and fair; and fair was the smile on her lips. Indescribable was the beauty of that sweet face. Its only comparison was the full moon. Balarām was anxious to find a bridegroom for Sujāti, the only child of the house. The best flowers from the garden were plucked every day and with them his wife daily worshipped the goddess, Mangal Chandi, praying for a suitable husband for her daughter.

Now, hear what took place next by a mere accident.

Sujāti, one day, went to the bathing-ghat of the river for taking her bath. The perfumed oil from her head spread its soft fragrance, and with a pitcher of water in her arms, she slowly went to *ghat* all alone.

The black clouds were broken and dispersed on all sides by the wild gusts of wind, which madly ran through the summer sky. Alone she stood on the landing steps, gazing at them. The waves of the river violently struck against the banks in their mad fury. There was no passer-by, no traveller, in that lonely region. So freely did she come down to knee-deep water and there washed her fair limbs. She descended still deeper into the river and washed her fair body. Then going down still deeper, with her neck outstretched, she looked on all sides with curious eyes. Just then she perceived that her pitcher of bell-metal was carried away by the waves into the mid-river. "Who will bring back to me my pitcher? Whom should I ask for it?" she thought, "There is no friend, none to help me here." The waves carried the pitcher far away from her. "Alas who will help me to get my pitcher back? I do not know how to swim. It was my fault that I came alone and this is the penalty I have paid. I have lost my pitcher. My parents will blame me. It is now high time to return. They will find fault with me for having come alone and lost the pitcher. How shall I return home with empty hands? O the winds, and the gods of heaven, may you graciously make the current blow to the contrary course, so that I may get my pitcher back."

The Herdsman.

"The winds, O fair girl, will not obey your order. But here is one, who will. I am getting back your pitcher for you. So return home and think no more of it."

Herdsman Lover



"Why does that sound forcibly capture my heart to-day." P. 47.

She was alone there and now they became a pair. On the landing-ghat of the river, four eyes met for the first time. She recognised the youth to be in charge of the buffaloes in her father's pasture, and then analysed her own feelings in secret. The colour of the Jabā flower reddened her face. This was her first youth and the dawning of the first happiness on her maidenly soul.

The young man brought the pitcher back and she carried it home, filling it with water.

He played on a reed-flute eight inches long, with pores at intervals; the burden of his song was, "O my own dear Rādhā, the abused one." Singing the song through his flute, the young shepherd returned to the pastures, after handing over the pitcher. Why is it that the maiden turned her head, again and again, to cast a glance at him to-day?

"I have seen you often. But to-day I discover graces in you, which are altogether new. Why does your flute like an enemy, seem to call me away from the duties of home to-day, to dazzling heights of pleasurable thoughts? Day after day have I seen you. But how is it that to-day the sight of you overpowers me with a strong emotion, as if my life would be unsupportable without you?"

In a room on the second floor of the three-storeyed house did she now enter to change her wet clothes, but her mind knew no rest at the sound of the flute.

"Many a time and oft have I heard the young herdsman sound his flute. But why does that sound forcibly capture my heart to-day? Is it not the same flute? But the tune to-day seems to be a new one. O my helpless lad, do you also bear a death-like pain in your heart in that lonely pasture-field as I do here, in this hall of my father? O my friend, let your buffaloes graze freely in the pastures on the banks of the yonder stream.

Be alone for a moment and hear me. Your flute has captivated a poor woman's heart. Why do you, my poor friend, expose your bare head to the scorching rays of the sun? Why do you allow yourself to be wet with rain? In yonder swamp grows many a lotus-plant. Get one of its large leaves and protect your head. Difficult it is to have a friend—a lover after one's mind. When such a one is found, many a trouble may have to be borne. One bears hurts from the thorns, when one stretches one's hands to pluck a lovely flower. A helpless woman am I, bearing a pain in my heart which cannot be expressed. Like unto a shoal, formed out of the sands of the bank, but unconnected with it, I live unattached to my family, though I was once part and parcel of it. For shame I cannot open my lips to express what I feel. I would have torn out my heart, if it were possible to show you its deep wound. I cannot express my pain to my parents either. A feeling of shame holds my tongue. From the day we first met on the landing-ghat, your flute has maddened me. How can I meet you, being a woman of the harem, always caring for society and its restrictions? The secret pain is unbearable. I try to advise my heart to reason and dissuade it from this mad attachment. But the mind's course cannot be stopped. My youth alas is waning away in deep anguish. No friend of mine knows my innermost thought; not a fly, not a worm has a knowledge of it. Reservedly do I keep my feelings confined to my heart. Were I a bird, how happy would I be, to see your face, sitting on a bough or flying in the air? Fain would I cut off all the ties of the family and would be near you, ministering to your comforts. How gladly would I wander with you, wherever you would go! And if the sun sent its burning rays, I would hold up a lotus-leaf to protect your head. How long

shall I deceive others and deceive myself in this way! My parents discuss the question of my marriage. Ah me! they do not know what is in my mind. If one's mind becomes madly devoted, what will social considerations do? Sweet is the cool water of the river, sweeter still the air, that gently blows over it. The milk of green cocoanuts is even sweeter than that air. Greater than these and immeasurably sweet is the first love in woman's heart. But the sweetness of getting a husband after one's own choice, one whom the heart elects, surpasses all other good fortunes of life. Just as the river sends sprays up in the air and in the blue azure these white little things shiningly play together, even so, above this dark human life do such a pair enjoy their blissful love. There is a plant of Champā, on which hang flowers, looking like a garland or like the smile of a sweet face. They are in full bloom and neither decay nor drop from the stalks. My heart yearns to prepare a wreath with them to be presented to you as a symbol of my constancy and love. Alas, I am reminded that I am not allowed to go out of this house! It is then that I feel how helpless I am."

These are some of the stray thoughts—the secret laments of the maiden's heart. (Ll. 1-102.)

(5)

Now let us see what the youth is doing in the pastures with the buffaloes in his charge.

When the clouds are rent by gusts of winds and the stars appear growing brightly from their midst, the young man thinks that they are beautiful like the eyes of the maiden.

The dark clouds fly above, spreading themselves rapidly over the azure,—the young herdsman imagines

the maiden to be going to the river-*ghat*, covered with her dark *sāri*.

The winds raise waves over the river in quick succession,—the youth is reminded of the wavy dance of the long flowing hair on the fair damsel's head.

The lotuses are in full bloom on the waters,—the young man imagines that the face of the girl is made of their soft blossoms.

Thus indulging in mad reveries, he became careless about his duties and did not watch the buffaloes in his charge.

Now hear what happened one day.

These beasts ate up the crops of the river-bank. The watchman reported to the Raja that Balarām's buffaloes had eaten up all the crops of the river-bank, belonging to His Highness.

The constables with long bamboo-clubs in their hands appeared before Balarām and wanted him peremptorily to present himself before the Raja's court. Balarām, with tears in his eyes, approached the palace of the Lord of the village in slow steps, while his wife and beautiful Sujāti trembled in fear as to what punishment Balarām would receive at the hands of the infuriated Zemindar.

Balarām now came near the gate-way of the court, where many soldiers, with their loin-cloths bound tight round their waists, brandished their long sticks and swords. They put him into a dungeon and there he remained for some time. Meanwhile Dingādhara approached the Raja with joined palms and thus submitted his prayer, "Do not, O lord, punish my master. In the name of God, I ask you not to take any violent steps against him. Be pleased to have me arrested in his stead, and I will make up for the loss Your Lordship has sustained, by serving you for full six years."

The buffaloes were confiscated to the State and Dingādhar's services were transferred to the Raja's pastures. The compensation being thus paid, Balarām was released, by the order of the Raja.

The maiden secretly lamented in her lonely apartment. "Alas, my friend, you have left our house for good! Helpless as I am, what can I do to save you? If it were possible, I would sell my nose-ornament and make up for the loss, caused by the buffaloes."

When called to dinner, she scarcely ate anything, and when retiring to sleep, she could scarcely close her eye-lids. The soft cushions she did not like, but spread the long flowing ends of her *sāri* and lay herself down on the bare floor. The father did not know her anguish; nor even her mother. Like fire smouldering in the saw-dust, grief burnt her heart slowly, unseen by others. This fire was not to be extinguished by water. "Else, my constant tears would have done it. Like the flow-tide is this youth of woman. If either crosses its limits, there is that general whisper and alarm." She thought.

(Ll. 1-44.)

(6)

Asharia Mandal is a notorious miser. When he sat to dine, he used to chain his cat, lest it should come too near and steal a morsel. His wife was almost in a state of nudity, yet he would not buy new clothes for her. His brother, in rage, would often slap him on the face for his extreme stinginess, and his son would abuse him and call him a contemptible mad fellow. But his charac-ter was not reformed. He slept on the bare floor and would not buy a mat. He wore a ragged loin-cloth and day and night counted his interest. He was a very

"crocodile of wealth," * and when he gave a loan to anybody, he would not remit a farthing of the interest. If any one came to him to clear his dues, he looked intensely into his account-books and calculated the interest minutely and exacted every farthing. He scarcely ate two meals; one was sufficient for him. No one saw him spend money for oil. When night came, he gathered a heap of dry leaves and made a fire to serve the purpose of a lamp.

After thinking wildly over his distressed condition, Balarām saw no way out of his difficulty, and applied for a loan to Ashāria, who gave him Rs. 500, making him swear, on his honour, to fulfil his strict conditions in due time.

Balarām paid a compensation to the Raja with the money and thus got his buffaloes released.

Out of kindness, the Raja granted a release to Dingā-dhara, after he had served for six months. But the youth had not the courage to return to Balarām's house. (Ll. 1-17.)

(7)

The river, in June, presented a wild spectacle of furious waves. Knowing not what course to follow, Dingādhar wandered about the bank with tearful eyes. He had no father, no mother, not even a brother, and his home on the Singākhāli lay deserted, there being none there to light the evening lamp.

He attempted to cross the river by swimming. But a great storm overtook him in the mid-river, and he was knocked at the head by the dashing waves and rendered unconscious. The river was very deep there and he was about to be drowned hopelessly. Fortunately, however,

* One who has hoarded great riches is generally called in this country a "crocodile of wealth."

a merchant from the east was passing that way with seven ships, laden with salt, molasses, rice, mustard, chilly, pepper, ginger and other agricultural products. His ship was manned by 22 oarsmen. He espied the struggling youth about to be drowned in the Surmā river and out of kindness, offered him help in time. He was brought to the ship. The merchant found his breath almost gone, and he was for sometime in doubt as to whether there was life in him. But the youth slowly rallied.

Dingādhar spent a year with the merchant, who treated him with great affection. In fact he enjoyed the position of the merchant's son in that house. The merchant one day told him, "This house, my boy, is yours. I have no children, nor any landed estate. These seven ships are all my property. And you have seen that I live by trade in countries, far and near."

Not long after, the merchant caught fever, due to exposure to northern breeze, and died. Dingādhar now became the master of the seven ships.

With these he made a voyage through the river Surmā and after many days, returned to his own native village on the bank of the Singākhāli. He constructed many goodly houses there, with doors open to the south. After being thus settled at home he remembered the beloved maiden Sujāti, whom he had not seen for the last five years. "How is she doing?" He asked to himself, "Has she been married by this time? Does she still think of me, after the lapse of so many years?"

He took a bag on his shoulders and a staff in his hand and thus disguised as a Fakir, went to Singāpur, the native place of Balarām.

The big houses he saw there on the point of collapsing. Balarām was dead and his home looked desolate and

deserted. From the unprotected roof the thieves stole straw, and the hedges and walls were broken by trespassers. The mother and the daughter occupied a corner of the house and lived in great fear, crying day and night. Dingādhar saw their miserable condition and his heart bled in sympathy.

He shouted like a beggar, asking for charity. Alas! they had not even a handful of rice to offer to the seeming Fakir. The maiden looked at him with tears in her eyes. She was herself a beggar, how could she help a beggar? There were a hundred patches in her '*sāri*' and she looked pale, like fire half hid in ashes. Dingādhar's heart broke at the sight. A silent cry rose in his heart, like when a spark of fire touches the store of gunpowder. (Ll. 1-50.)

(8)

He returned home, convinced that Sujāti was still unmarried. He sent a match-maker to Balarām's house. The mother offered him a wooden seat and received him with respect. He addressed her and said, "Your daughter, I see, has stepped into her youth. She is exceedingly handsome. In fact, I have not seen a girl so beautiful in the locality. I am a match-maker and travel far and near in quest of brides. If you wish, I may try to secure a bridegroom for your daughter. Now tell me your views. I have, on my list, a score of suitable youths, ready for engagement. Say what conditions would you like to propose."

The poor mother's eyes were almost blinded with tears. She saw darkness all around her. Slowly did she say. "The merchant Balarām died, leaving a debt of Rs. 500; a marriage-proposal has been forced upon us on account of his debt. All the buffaloes and our pastures have

been mortgaged to the money-lender. We have thus been able to clear half of our debts and prayed for a little extention of time. Six months was granted, during which the remaining money must be paid. Should we fail to do so, Ashāria would seize our house and property and forcibly get my daughter married to his son. Thus the poor girl is to be given away in lieu of her father's debt. Ashāria belongs to a low-caste Urumbariā community. He is resolved to ruin our social status in this way. But know, my dear sir, before I agree to this dishonourable proposal, I will cut my daughter to pieces with my own hand and float the corpse in the river, and then drown myself there. There is only one week in hand; so the time has nearly expired. We do not know what will befall us in the interval.

The Match-maker.

"I will get your house and property released by clearing your debt. Within seven days you will see it all done."

The match-maker returned on the fourth day and cleared the debt with interest to the last farthing. The property was released and the house thoroughly repaired.

The match-maker raised again the question of marriage, but did not disclose the name of Dingādhar. The maiden Sujāti now thought over the matter. The date of marriage could no longer be put off. She took recourse to a pretext and said to the match-maker, "There was a young man in charge of the buffaloes of our house in my father's time. He was appointed for six years, but having served us only for six months, left this house. I do not know his present whereabouts, nor the name of his native village. The condition of my marriage is this. This youth should be found out. Myself and my mother are helpless women. Who will take

charge of our buffaloes ? We cannot go to the pastures and keep watch over them.

The match-maker went to Dingādhar with the message.

When he heard this, Dingādhar disguised himself as a match-maker, and went to the house of the maiden. He bound his long hair into a knot, after the manner of a match-maker and spread an umbrella of split bamboos over his head. Arriving at Singāpur, he approached the maiden and made a hurried speech to this effect. "I am a brother of the match-maker, who lately called here. We have now heard of your strange condition. You should have told of it beforehand. We have repaired and reconstructed the houses and paid off your debt to Ashāria. The marriage is fixed. The bridegroom has already come here and is staying on his boat in the river. Now what pretexts are these ? Where can you expect us to find out your young herdsman ? Who is he ? We do not know. However, I am prepared to take charge of your buffaloes and serve as your servant from to-day. Now be true to the engagement and consent to the marriage." Saying so, he threw away his false hair and the guise of a match-maker. He became once more the young herdsman he was, by wearing a cap on his head and taking the shepherd's crook in his hand. The maiden looked intently at the youth and now recognised her herdsman-lover. He had the same flute in his hand, and sang a song—that old song, which had captivated Sujāti's mind on the bank of the Surmā.

The drums and tabors were beaten and the music of Sānāi's note was heard from afar. Beautiful Sujāti was thus married to Dingādhar.* (Ll. 1-82.)

* After this we have some lines, composed by the ministrel, who sang this ballad, to this effect :—

"When this part of the poem was sung, the audience became excited with joy. The night is far advanced. Will you give us a '*Silim*' of tobacco ? After a little recreation and smoking we will resume the story.

(9)

Meghuā, a merchant of Chittagong, was passing by the river Surmāi with his five ships. The oars were coloured red and blue, and as they struck the waves, a musical note arose, filling the air with the sound. The river, struck by the oars, was in commotion, presenting a spectacle of wild turmoil.

The oarsmen and the Captain asked the fishers, who were throwing nets into the river, "Will you tell us, friends, the name of this country?" "Go a little up," said they, "and you will find the landing-steps, known as Dingādhar's '*pāt*,' near the bend of the river."

The landing-steps were made of stone. Here the young wife Sujāti was bathing. She looked beautiful as the full-moon. She was dressed in her blue '*sāri*,' through which the lustre of her body shone forth in bright contrast. There, sitting on the landing-steps, she opened the five-fold braids of her chignon and with the end of her '*sāri*' wiped away the red dye from her feet.

Staying in the mid-river, Meghuā looked at her beauty and was charmed. She looked like a fairy with her blue '*sāri*,' her moon-like face and the curling hair which fell loosely round her head. She was busy with her toilet-articles on the landing-*ghat*, but when she saw foreign people coming on a ship, she hastily took the pitcher in her arm and in slow steps walked towards her home.

She went all alone. Meghuā ordered his ships to cast anchor there and, for sometime, sat musing, forgetful of himself. When evening came, he set out for Dingādhar's house.

In a pleasure-house, raised in the midst of a tank, Dingādhar sat in a happy mood, when Meghuā paid him

a visit and offered himself as a guest of the house for the night. On pretext of friendship, he spent the night there. He incidentally talked over many matters, concerning the prospects of his trade and said, "In the north there is a place called Arang. I am going there for trade. It is a strange place. In exchange of rice, they give us large quantities of gold. They are greatly fond of dried fish, which is not available in that country. For some quantity of dried fish, they would give us a golden cup. For shaddock they would offer precious stones. In their country there are no betels or nuts. If they get these, they would gladly give oyster-pearls. They accept banana, cocoanut and other fruits in exchange of gold-leaves."

These accounts inflamed the imagination of Dingādhar and he started for that northern city for trade with his false friend. He took leave of his wife Sujāti and in great speed, in six days, he performed a journey, which, in usual course, would take six long months.

It was evening and the sun was setting with glittering rays. The ships were going fast over the waters, aided by the playful winds. At a certain place, Meghuā ordered his boatmen to cast anchor with a foul motive. Dingādhar entered his friend's ship for the purpose of playing at dice. There after playing for hours, Dingādhar fell asleep in his friend's cabin.

Now the wicked Meghuā cut off the ropes of his ship which went straight to the sea with Dingādhar, carried by the current; and the oarsmen and others on Dingādhar's ship lay unconscious in deep sleep and the people of Meghuā, at a signal from their master, led the other ship against the tide, which, aided by favourable winds, marched off, with sails unfurled. (Ll. 1-60.)

(10)

In the morning Sujāti was taking rest in her own compartment, accompanied by her female attendants. Buddhu, a servant of the house came with the report that a rumour ran in the city to the effect that the master of the house was coming back.

Sujāti, when she heard it, went to her toilet-room and wore a '*sāri*,' gorgeous like the tail of a peacock. In her arms, she wore bracelets and an armlet. She adorned her chignon with a garland of Champa-flower and over it put some golden bees. Near her forehead, she wore golden stars, and a *besar* adorned her nose. A pair of golden pendants of the pattern of '*Jhumka*' flower hang from her ears ; and when she wore the red sign of luck on her forehead, verily did she look like Lakshmi, the harvest-goddess. On her feet sounded her anklets, making a merry jingling sound.

She made ready a flat basket with sacred articles, chiefly blades of grass, a handful of rice and some sacred things, which were first offered to the goddess 'Bana Durga.' Her husband had returned after six months, and she was there to give a due reception to his ships, performing the sacred rites. She came to the river-*ghat* and recognised her husband's ship. She was now to take the goods and treasures from it, observing the usual ceremonies. She came down to the river and first made a sign with vermilion on the prow and placed on it the blades of grass and a few grains of rice. After long days her husband had returned. Her heart was full of joy and a smile adorned her lips. At this stage, the devil of Meghuā appeared there and with the suddenness of a vulture, which swoops down upon a fish, about to be cut by the fisher's knife, seized Sujāti and carried her to the

ship. Then at a signal from him, his men immediately started the ships, which being favoured by the strong current, flew off like a flash. The clouds were roaring in the sky and the sails were aided by high winds. The people on the bank stood stupified by the suddenness of the action. In an instant the ship went out of sight so fast that they could not believe that such a thing hat really happened before their eyes. Sujāti was seen last time striking her head with her hands. It was like the Rakshasa carrying off Sita from her sylvan home. (Ll. 1-35.)

INCOMPLETE.

THE YOUNG HERDSMAN.

(A Second Version.)

The Young Herdsman.

(1)

"O my youthful herdsman, O my friend, my heart weeps for you! From where do you sound your flute? I look on all sides in vain and see you not on the banks of the Surmāi."

"On one side of the Surmāi, I see the bank, risen to great height, all black, and off on the other, it is all white with sands. Between her black and white banks, flows the Surmāi. From where dost thou sound your flute in this region? I cannot see thee. The Hijal-tree stands high there, I ask it, "Will you tell me, my good tree, who sounds the flute so sweetly?"

"The blossoming Champā and the flowers of the screw-plants adorn this bank of the river. Here have I lost all control over my heart at the sound of your flute. My social ties, my family honour have now no meaning for me."

Her pitcher which was full to the brim, she empties and, on pretext of fetching water, she goes to the river-*ghat* and gazes around.

The water, which is emptied from the pitcher, is sucked by the earth and, with it, the tears that fall from her eyes. She cannot see the path through her tears and says, "O my bee, why do you not come to the flower, which has bloomed for you." (Ll. 1-16.)

(2)

So indifferent was she to everything else, while listening to the flute, that she knew not that her pitcher had

been carried away by the current and floated far off. The sound of the flute captured her heart completely. She sat on the landing-steps and opened the five braids from her chignon. From under her wet *sāri*, her dazzling beauty appeared like a flash. With the help of a *gilla* (seed of scandres), she cleansed her body and wiped away the dirt with the end of her flowing *sāri*. The red dye of her feet was washed away by the waves of the river. She came down to knee-deep water and washed her fair feet; she descended still down and washed her fair limbs and then coming down still deeper, her body fully merged in water,—with her neck stretched out,—she cast her glance, full of curiosity, on all sides. From the other bank of the river, came floating at this moment the sound of the youngman's flute. The air was sporting and became resonant with the sweet music. The girl found her senses completely subdued by the flute's appeal. The black clouds were moving wildly, driven by the winds. From what depth of the forest was the flute singing so sweetly?

"Day by day have I heard the sound of this flute. But never felt its maddening effect as greatly as to-day. Ye, bees, that are flying from one flower to another in the grove of the screw-plants, in quest of honey, will you tell me, who it is that plays on the flute? Show me the path, so that I may find him at last. My eyes are nearly blinded with tears. Every day I come to the *ghat* in quest of him. I came yesterday, and have come to-day. But in vain goes my search for the player of the flute. Had I known how to swim, fain would I cross the river and catch him on the other bank."

The western clouds went flying to the eastern sky. The pitcher of bell-metal was carried by the current far off. Her day-dream vanished, and coming back to her

senses, she perceived the helplessness of her situation. Who would help her to bring the pitcher back? It danced on the waves and went far away. She did not know how to swim. What should she do now?

"At an evil hour did I come to the *ghat*. My pitcher is lost. My parents will take me to task. It is high time to return. I shall be rebuked for coming to the river all alone and losing the pitcher in this way. How shall I return home with empty hands? O the winds, and the gods of the sky, order the current to take the contrary course, so that it may bring my pitcher back to me. O river, so cruelly sportive have you been; flow with favourable tide to get me back my lost thing."

The Herdsman.

"The winds will not obey your orders, nor the river. But here is one who will. I will get for you the pitcher back, you may return home quite at ease."

It was midday. He came to me with a cap on his head and a shepherd's crook in his hand—a perfect stranger to me. I had been alone, but now we became a pair. This meeting was ordained by Providence, and so we met."

A sense of shame coloured her face with the scarlet hue of the Javā flower. This was her first youth and this was the dawning of the first happiness on her maidenly soul. The bee imprints a kiss on the flower and leaves a sign. The impression of this meeting, likewise, made a sign on her heart, never to be effaced.

The youth brought her back the pitcher. And she filled it with water, and carrying it on her arms, she was about to return home, when she softly said, "Who are you, handsome youth? I never saw you before, nor heard of you. You have really offered me a great help

to-day, when I needed it most. The sound of your flute and the sweetness of your smile have such a charming effect on my mind! I cannot resist it."

The Herdsman.

"I tend my cattle on the other bank of the river. My buffaloes graze in yonder pasture. In that unprotected land, scorching rays of the sun burn me, and when rain comes, I become drenched with it. So do I sing a song of my sorrows through this flute to assuage the pain of my heart—not that others would hear it. From to-day I will wait in yonder avenue of *hijal* trees and you will come with your pitcher for water here. I will stay on the other bank and you will be here. It will be only for a sight of your face—nothing more."

He carried with him a reed-flute, eight inches long, with holes at interval. On other days, he used to sing the name of Rādhā through his flute. But how is it that a strange tune sounds from his flute to-day?

The Maiden's Soliloquy.

"Why to-day has such a change come over your spirit, my friend? Your flute, it seems, is pursuing me like an enemy, calling me away from home, to an uncertain life of danger. From day to day have I heard the sound of your flute, but its music comes to-day with a strange message for me. It seems, a great trouble it will bring to my life."

When she was robing herself after her bath in her pleasure-house, rich with floral wreaths, she listened with all-absorbing attention to the music of the flute, that came from the far-off groves of screw-plants.

"How plaintive is the sound! Is it the same flute on which he used to play before or another? The

pathos of the sweet music fills the mind with alarm; is the poor youth going to die of despair?

"Leave your buffaloes, dear lad, in the pastures on the bank of the milky river. Do you know that your flute has charmed the soul of a helpless woman? Why, my beloved, why do you expose yourself to the alternate freaks of the season—to the burning rays of the sun, or to the incessant rain, that drenches your body? Why not secure a leafy branch from yonder tree and thereby protect your head? How helpless am I! Fain would I wipe away the drops of sweat on your brow, caused by the sun and minister to your comforts!"

Thus did she lament in a wild manner in her lonely chamber. Now hear what happened to the herdsman in the pastures. (Ll. 1-84.)

(3)

The bright stars peeped through the clouds, torn by the gusts of wind in the azure, the youth looked at them and became reminded of the soft eyes of the maiden. And when the dark clouds flew in sportive ways, spreading themselves over the sky, the youth thought of his love, clad in her dark-blue *sāri*, sportively going to the river-side. The playful winds created an array of flowing waves on the river and this reminded him of the wavy dance of the long curling hair, that fell on her back. The beautiful lotuses, that bloomed in the water made him think of the maiden's sweet face, which he fancied to be made of soft petals of lotus.

Thus thinking always of the maiden he became indifferent to everything else and forgot his duties to watch and tend the buffaloes. Now hear what took place one day.

The buffaloes, uncared for, in the pasture made a raid in the corn-field near the bend of the river and ate up the crops. The field belonged to the Rājā of the place and his men reported to him of the damage.

The constables and peons, with long bamboo-clubs in their hands, marched to the place, bound the youth, hand and foot, and brought him to the Rājā, who took possession of all his buffaloes and ordered him to be banished from his country.

The river Surmāi looked menacingly in June and flowed in its mad course. The young herdsman wandered about its banks in despair. No mother, no father had he, nor even a brother or friend. Whither he was to go, he knew not. He was like a bird, flying in the infinite sky without aim or destination.

"O river, your course is towards the southern places ; tell my love, if ever she happens to come to your banks, that her friend, the youth has drowned himself. Ye, black bees, that hover in the sky, tell her that the herdsman is no more. Ye, kites, that fly above the tops of the bamboo-groves and ye, crows that croak, sitting on the boughs of yonder tree, tell the maiden that her beloved friend has died of unbearable grief."

The herdsman tied his clothes like a rope round his neck and jumped into the river. The waves came on, furiously dashing and well nigh drowned him. The river was very deep at this spot. But providence wished it otherwise. A merchant from the east was going by that river with seven ships, which were laden with rice, chilly, salt, ginger and other agricultural products. The merchant's residential ship, which was the biggest, was plied by 22 oarsmen. From the water, they picked up the half-dead youth.

Thus saved from death, he stayed with the merchant and learned from him the secrets of his trade. The merchant gave him the name of Dingādhar or master of the ships. After a time Dingādhar was sent by his master to the Garo Hills for trade. When he was returning, he saw on the way large bamboo-groves. He cut a bamboo and made a flute with it. (Ll. 1-48.)

(4)

Let me here revert to the story of the maiden's love. Separated from her young lover her beauty faded away. Her rich hair became knotted and wild like jute. Careless of her apparel, she ate little and had scarcely any desire for toilets.

The parents tried to assuage the pain of her heart, not knowing what it was, but all in vain. The very beasts of the forest and birds of the air seemed to feel a sympathy for her; while all alone, she lamented thus.

"I am a feeble maiden, O my friend! and feel as if my heart is on fire. Like a shoal, produced by the sands of the bank but owned neither by the river nor by the bank, I find myself cut off from all. Alas, I began to love as a child but felt its pain at the threshold of youth."

"How difficult it is to select the object of one's love! If one wishes to get a lovely flower, one should be prepared to encounter thorns. I feel shame in expressing my sentiments. To whom may I open the doors of my heart and show my innermost thoughts?

"The sportive winds play with the flower and tear its petals. Even so has Fate rent my heart. It is a great pity that I cannot tell my sad tale to my parents.

"I cannot go out of my house, lest people should blame me, but like a bird, sickened in the cage, my mind distressed by its environment, fancies itself flying in the free air.

"How sincerely do I try to dissuade my mind from this mad course, but in vain. The pitcher of my life, once full, is gradually losing its liquid treasure. The beasts of the forest know it not, nor do the birds of the air know what my grief is. Insupportable is this grief of mine unshared by others.

"Had I been a bird, I would have sat on a bough of the tree and seen your face, day and night, to my heart's content. No more can I thus deceive myself. My parents are discussing the question of my marriage.

Sweet is the air that blows over the waters. Sweeter still is the milk in a cocoanut. But sweeter than that is the first love in the dawn of youth. Sweeter than all these and immeasurably sweet is to a woman the husband of her own choice.

The playful waves rise high, driven by the winds. They send forth white sprays in the dark azure, which look like white flowers in the midst of dark ones. Verily are the lovers like these white sprays, living in bliss in the midst of dark evils attending life.

Look at the blooming Champā flowers! From whose neck has a garland dropped on the plants? Whose smile is it that shows itself in these full-blown flowers? They do not drop from the stalks, nor do they fade. When I go to the garden to pluck these, my eyes grow tearful. When I sleep in the night, I see in my dreams a figure sweet as yours,—my young friend."

Thus did the beautiful maiden lament day and night.

(Ll. 1-44.)

(5)

Now my topic will be the story of a merchant, named Meghuā, a native of Chittagong. He was going by the river in a pinnace plied by sixteen oars. Meghuā heard the sweet sound of a flute, when he was near a bend of the river. It was so sweet that the very current seemed to flow in a contrary direction, in order to listen to the music.

Dingādhar and Meghuā met there and both were pleased with one another. The merchant said to the youth, "My home is at Chittagong. Let us both go there. I would ask you to stay at my home for a full year. Then both of us will set out for some foreign country for trade."

(6)

From the bough of a tree, the cuckoo's note was heard and the night bade its farewell at this sweet signal. On the floor of her room the maiden laid herself down, lamenting her separation from the youthful herdsman.

"Why is it, O cuckoo, that your note has lost its usual charm? And who is it, O sky, that has robbed thee of the glory of moonbeams? He went away long ago. Meantime, many a flower bloomed and faded away. Just as the honey of a blooming flower dries within itself, the well of my happiness has become dry within."

One night she rose up from her sleep—all startled. It was the sound of *his* flute, no doubt of it, that she heard.

She did not say anything to her father, nor to her mother. She had become completely fearless and cared not what the consequences of her action would be. In the morning the parents would fill the air with their laments and the neighbours would abuse her as an

unchaste woman. But she thought neither of this nor of that. As soon as she heard the sound of the flute, she straightway made for the landing *ghat*. The sky was covered with clouds and the night wore the hue of collyrium. The moon had completely disappeared behind the clouds. To the river she went, following the sound of the flute. Yea, the neighbours would call her a bad woman and revile her. The parents would be overwhelmed with grief. But she thought neither of this, nor of that. With her herdsman on the boat of his friend, she left the country.

It was like a bird, cutting by its beak the bars of its cage. She thought of the frantic sorrow it would cause to her mother and of the grief of her father. She shed a few drops of tear at the recollection. When the neighbours would call her a bad woman, what would be the feelings of her poor mother? How will she bear it?

With sixteen oars the pinnace of Meghuā flew like a bird over the river. They shortly reached Chittagong, the native place of the merchant.

One full year rolled by. The maiden could not be traced by her parents. Her beauty smote Meghuā with love. She was neither tall nor short-statured. Her hair was soft and curling. Meghuā became mad as he gazed on her beautiful figure. (Ll. 1-47.)

(7)

Meghuā (*to the Herdsman*).

"Hear me, O friend, how long shall we pass our time at home in this idle manner? I engaged carpenters to repair my ship. They have made it ready for a sea-voyage. Let us go to the north for trade. You are not probably aware of the prospects of trade in those regions.

I will tell you something of them, which will be interesting to you. The womenfolk there earn money by hard work. The males are lazy fellows and sit idly at home. In the public market, you will see women only as sellers and purchasers. In their rivers, pearls and precious stones are found in abundance. These they secure by nets. So great is their number that they store them without counting. In exchange of very ordinary goods, they give very large quantities of gold. If you can supply dried fish, they will give you hoards of money, measuring in the scales. They are madly fond of tortoise and goat. If we take with us some of these animals, we are sure to get countless gold and silver in return. Let us secure these and try our luck. If a person goes to trade to that country but once, he will hoard up so much wealth that his sons and grandsons will not be in need of going abroad for trade. The money acquired by a merchant, will make the family well-off for at least three generations."

After having made the head of his friend Dingādhar giddy with this false and exaggerated report, Meghuā went into the inner apartments of his house and saw his sister Maynā.

Meghuā.

"Hear me, my dear sister, I am going to the North for trade. The moon-faced maiden, we have secured, I leave to your care. Cover her with your flowing *sari* just as you would do a dearly prized treasure. Keep her in close custody—shut up within the walls of this house, so that even the sun or the moon, not to speak of any outsider, may not have a peep at her. I will return after six months and then shall I find a suitable bridegroom for her and think of her marriage. I will make for her

a gold necklace and purchase a *sari* as white as the waves of the Ganges. She will, moreover, have nose ornaments, and gold bracelets for her arms, and anklets for her feet."

With these allurements, he tried to please the maiden, and set out on his voyage, accompanied by his friend.

The boat of Meghuā was plied by sixteen oarsmen, and that of Dingādhar by thirteen. Meghuā's boat went ahead, and the latter's behind.

In the North there is a large tract of land, inhabited by the Garos and the Kookis. These men are fierce like the Rākshasas and eat human flesh. No one, who travels there, has a chance of returning to his native country. Meghuā determined to send his friend thither on some pretext. After crossing thirteen bends of the river 'Surmāi' they came near a junction, and Meghuā here addressed his friend and said, "There are two courses of the river here. Yonder dark and furious stream leads to the land of the *Kāmunis* (Kamaksya). You had better proceed by it, against the tide. You will reach a place, full of fabulous wealth. I will go by the other stream, which leads to the country of Bharais. Now let us try our luck in two opposite directions for a period of six months. If you happen to come earlier, let your boat be moored here at this junction and please wait for me. If I come earlier, you will find me waiting. Both of us will go home together from here."

Thus they followed the two different streams. Now hear of the misfortune, brought on by Providence.

The clouds which had the look of the brownish knotted locks of Siva, the God of Destruction, rolled on menacingly in the sky. The winds with the furious voice of a challenge blew over the river. The turbulent waves broke the banks as high as hills and jumped like wrestlers. Who knows where wicked Meghuā was carried

away, dashed by the waves? Dingādhar thought "Meghuā, like a traitor, has certainly led me astray."

The thirteen oarsmen cried out in one voice, "Master, it is impossible to go against the tide. Shall we return home? Kindly give us order to do so." The ropes of the sail were all torn and the helm was on the point of breaking. They could no longer control the boat. At this crisis, Dingādhar complied with the wishes of his men, and ordered them to ply homewards. It would take six months in going ahead against the tide. But the same distance could be traversed in thirteen days, if the boat followed the current.

He went to Meghuā's native country in quest of the maiden. Meantime, a rumour spread there that Meghuā's boat was capsized by storm. Three years passed and Dingādhar stayed at Meghuā's home, waiting for his return. But as he did not turn up within this long time, Dingādhar felt sure that he must have died. So after some waverings and hesitancy, he married Maynā, the merchant's sister. (Ll. 1-72.)

(7)

There was a Raja in Chittagong whose name was Kengu. He was a tyrant and oppressed his subjects. He had seven hundred good-looking women in his harem. But even this number did not appease his desire for the fair sex. He was always in lookout for handsome women, and ready to marry any number of them.

Four years rolled by, and the fifth was also going to expire, when Meghuā returned home, a wreck of his former self. His body looked like a thin piece of wood, and his beard had grown grey. On returning home after these long years, Meghuā saw what had happened in his family during his absence. He was inflamed like

a blazing fire, fed by butter. He called all his neighbours and friends to his house and wanted an explanation. They all said that their information was that he had been drowned. Most of them failed even to recognise him. His hair, which had been jet-black, was now grey. Some of them thought that Meghuā had died and that it was his ghost that they saw before them. So they tried to drive him away from the village. Some wanted to have him arrested for false personation. Others advised patience and a full consideration of the matter before taking any steps. Those, who had borne him a grudge, now availed themselves of this opportunity and gave him some blows.

Being dealt at home in this rough manner, Meghuā went to Raja Kengu and lodged a complaint that his friend had played false with him. He had left his wife at home and gone for trade. This friend now turned into an enemy and took possession of his wife. He besides, married his sister Maynā. With the two women, the wicked man was enjoying himself in his home. He drove him away by force on his return. With this complaint Meghuā stood before the Raja, supplicant for justice.

Now I am going to describe to you how the Raja disposed of this case. He took a great interest when he heard of the two women. It was reported that they were exquisitely handsome ; so he forthwith sent constables to bring them up before him. They were now presented before the Raja, who passed the order of death by impalement on Dingādhar. At this stage, listen to what Sujāti, the maiden did.

* * * *

"He is my brother but has become my enemy."—cried Maynā and her laments made even the beasts of forest and birds of the air sad. (Ll. 1-34.)

KANCHANMĀLĀ

The Bride of a Blind Baby.

PREFACE.

The song of Kānchanmālā, or the bride of a blind baby, is a *Gītikathā*.

The *Gītikathās*, as I have defined them in my 'Folk Literature of Bengal,' are tales, narrated in prose, interspersed with songs. The prose-portions are sometimes less genuine, as the singers have simplified the archaic forms of the language in course of reciting them through generations. The chief interest of this class of tales lies in the poetical portions, which are full of the unadorned simplicity of rustic life, though the language is oftentimes crude.

The tale of Kānchanmālā was collected by Babu Chandra Kumar from two men chiefly. The major portion he secured from one Hara Chandra Barmā of Marichali (P. O. Dauhakhola) and the remaining part he got from Ramkumar Mistri of Aithor (P. O. Kendua). The two versions do not seem exactly to fit each other. In the first version, it is indicated that Kānchanmālā left her father's palace with her blind husband, disgusted with her father's capricious conduct. While, in the concluding portion of a second version that we have secured, it is distinctly stated that she was banished to the forest, owing to the wily contrivance of her step-mother. There is, however, no mention of a step-mother of the unfortunate girl in the first version of the tale.

It seems that many of these Gītikathās had several versions, which, though agreeing in the main with one another, differred in minor details.

I am sorry to find that the Gītikathā, as given in the following pages, does not appear to have retained its genuineness in all parts. We have always found, in

these ballads and songs, instances of spirited women, whose minds are untrammelled by tradition or conventional ideas. The heroine has suffered all that a human being can endure for the sake of love; but we scarcely find in these tales a trumpeting of Brahminical canons in regard to wifely duties and devotion. Here, however (LC 31-44, Canto 10) there is that distinct ring of propagandic ideas of the later artificial school. The stereotyped phrases of Brahminic wisdom, such as "আসমানে সবুজ যেমন রাত্রিকালের বাতি। সেই মত ঘরের মধ্যে সতী নারীর পতি॥" (LC 39-40, Canto 10) "সতীর না পতি যেমন সাপের মাথার মণি" (LC 31, Canto 10) are here and there preached in long speeches, sounding a discordant note in a field, which is full of the warblings of Nature's glee birds. These sentiments seem particularly sickening and irrelevant, when a girl of fourteen is found to lament in that style over the loss of her husband, only six years old. The minstrel, who sang this song before an assembly of men, imbued with the new ideas of the Brahminic school, must have tried to introduce some wise sayings, current in the air at his time, however ill-suited they might be to the occasion, in order to humour his audience.

But though the minstrel's interpolations contain some burlesque elements, marring the naïve simplicity of the song, it is only occasionally that we find this to be the case; the general spirit of the whole has remained true to the characteristic charm of rural life. It is interesting to notice the vivid accounts of the forests of Mymensingh—full of 'Dāruk'-trees and the swamps, abounding with lotuses. Graphic are the descriptions of the wanderings of Kānchan, parted from her husband, through countries full of *sundhā methi*—sweet-smelling shrubs, whose leaves yield the red dye for decorating a woman's feet,—through wild tracts, with scarce human

habitations, where men live in the company of serpents, bears and tigers, often dying in the hands of these enemies in the forest,—and through the chilly regions of the north, where the Kookis, the Gāros and other hill-tribes live in a state of perfect nudity and eat human flesh. The simple portraiture of his native land by the peasant-poet is really charming; it is so life-like that the reader occasionally hears, as it were, the roarings of clouds, and sees the landscape, lit up by lightning—vividly, brought before the eye, by a poet, in whose simple soul Nature seems to be mirrored in her true colours.

The account of the forest-life and of the joyful days that the Prince spent with Kānchan, given by him in a somewhat veiled language, lest it should hurt his wife's feelings, and the clever manner in which Kunjalatā drew from him, unawares, the story of his childhood, bring out, by contrast, the psychological phenomenon of two struggling hearts, not actuated by candour but by a motive to suppress facts from each other. The subsequent events, happening by the agency of the green-eyed monster jealousy, are drawn with exceedingly subtle hands, showing that our unlettered poet was no mean artist but an adept in all matters relating to the tender susceptibilities of the human heart. When Kānchan slept, stealthily did the prince stand by her, and looking on all sides with watchful eyes, lest he should be discovered, would gently fan her. But he could not hide his action from the ever-wakeful and vigilant eyes of the princess. At times the princess perceived that through the apertures of doors, he was intensely gazing at the sweet face of Kānchan. It was the cruellest cut of all, however, when the Prince, while going on a hunting excursion, one day, took leave of Kānchan but forgot to say a parting

word to his wife. Such omissions, however regrettable, are but natural, when the mind yields to a new fascination. (Canto 15, Prose, Line 7.)

During the absence of the Prince from home, at a deep hour of night when the inmates of the palace were all asleep, and the clouds were roaring and the rain falling in incessant streams, Kānchan, requested by the princess Kunjalatā, with her voice choked with tears, told her the story of her forest-life,—how in the huts of reeds, covered with creepers and flowers, she lived with the old man and his wife,—how her boy-husband blossomed like a wild flower in the fresh air and light of the solitude and she delighted in him as the greatest treasure of her heart, till at last he was carried away forcibly by the King (Canto 17, Lines 15-38). In all this simple narration there is an appreciation of rural life with its simple pathos which we miss in our modern artificial poetry.

The most elevating portion of the tale is that in which the great renunciation of Kānchan is described. She wanted that her husband should be cured of his blindness. She offered the Sanyasi all that he might demand of her, for this great favour. She was ready to give up her kingdom and riches and would fain wander with her lord in the forest, as she once did, living upon fruits and vegetable roots. "Cure him of his blindness at any cost, and if all that I have offered is not enough, take out my eyes. I will prefer to remain blind all my days but let my husband have his eyes restored." (Canto 24, Lines 13-16.)

She was turned out from the palace by the plottings of her co-wife Kunjalatā. This had no doubt sharpened her bitter feelings towards her. The Sannyasi knew it and hit at her weak point. He said, "All right. Here is a fruit, give it to your co-wife and with it, give your

husband and your kingdom to *her*. You will never be permitted to see your husband any more. He will be hers for ever."

"There is another condition besides: when offering the fruit and, with it, your husband and kingdom to the co-wife, you are not to feel any pang in your heart. You will neither sigh nor sob, nor drop a tear. If you can pass through this ordeal with a tranquil mind, eyesight will be restored to your husband. But if you feel the least tremor in your heart he will remain stone-blind as he is."

What a trial! Here see the Hindu woman in all her towering strength and firmness, evoked by love. Turn over the pages of these ballads and songs and again and again behold the superb spectacle of renunciation and sacrifice, which are only possible by means of super-human love—a patience, which only a statue may show, but not a creature of flesh and blood.

In a moment she collected herself, like the great prince Rāma, on the eve of giving up his kingdom,—"ধারয়ন্ মনসা দুঃখং ইন্দ্রিয়াণি নিগৃহ্য চ." For a moment she felt herself to be dedicated at the altar of love. She had no right to weep, no right to sigh,—lest her husband should lose this great chance. She rendered herself into a stone, nay more, she even felt elated at the thought that by her supreme sacrifice, her husband would be saved. Inwardly feeling a contentment that her husband would again see the smiling face of Nature, she turned herself away and never looked again at him, surrendering a privilege, which was prized by her more than paradise. Is this not a sight for gods to see?

How could these peasants conceive such a noble ideal of love? Is it not really wonderful that crude minds without any culture, driving the plough through

fields and tending the cattle all their life, could conceive and appreciate these wonderful virtues in womankind ?

It appears that the Buddhist ideal of noble self-abnegation and suppression of animal-passions gradually filtered down to the lowest stratum of our society and rendered this world of ours into a paradise of the highest virtues of the soul.

In the following epoch of our history, when the Buddhist ideas passed away and stress was laid upon Bhakti or devotion, we begin to see another side of the picture. The tendencies of the age favoured abstract virtues, soaring above the secular plain. Prayers, fasts, vigils, ecstasies and esoteric joys became the craze of the spiritually-awakened soul. And in the place of a Maluā, a Lila, a Madinā and a Kanchanmālā, we have had other types, such as Dhruba, Prahlad, and many other heroes of faith, described in the Puranas. With the age of the ballads and songs, we have lost the period of the secular school, elevated by its romantic ideas of love, and gained access to a new world, of which the characteristics are spiritual bliss and abstract devotion.

D. C. SEN.

KĀNCHANMĀLĀ

The Bride of a Blind Baby.

Prologue.

O my audience, pray accept my salutes. Be kind to hear this account of Kānchanmālā with patience.

I have no knowledge of the science of music and may not always keep time with the instruments. My only hope is that my master, who taught me the art of singing, has blessed me. His blessings, I hope, will carry me safe through all trials.

The sky is square-shaped and is lighted by stars. There the spirits and fairies wander in the air. Their palaces are made of clouds, shining like mica. Without any lamp there is light there. On the walls of their mansions illuminations are fixed. The doors are all made of gold, and bolts are of the same metal. On all sides, gold glitters and illuminates the background of deep purple. In such palaces live the spirits and fairies. On bedsteads, made of mica, they enjoy sound sleep.

I shall relate to you incidents of one particular day.

Kānchanmālā is dancing before an assembly of spirits and fairies. The cymbals are being played by a musician, who sits close by her.

The spectators are beholding the sight with breathless interest. She is dancing, standing on and lightly touching a clay vessel.[1]

[1] The Indian dancing girl of yore used to dance, lightly touching a clay vessel with her toes. This unburnt vessel was naturally so brittle, that a slight pressure was enough to break it. The girl rested her whole weight on the air barely touching the vessel with her feet by a peculiar occult training. If the vessel broke under the pressure of the feet, she was branded as unsuccessful.

Small bells are ringing from her waist-belt and the anklets are jingling, keeping time with the music. Her toes scarcely touch the clay-vessel; so agile is her motion that she seems to rest her whole weight on the air.

She was playing her part excellently well. But evil was in her luck. Suddenly, the clay-vessel broke, touched by her feet.

The king of the fairy-land was angry at this and cursed Kanchanmala. His first word of curse made her braids all loose. The second word made her ornaments drop from her tender body; but there it did not end. As he pronounced the third word, a death-like pallor spread on her face and her eyes lost the power of sight.

King.

"Though you are a free spirit—a fairy, be thou born in the mortal land—in the house of mortals. For twenty years thou shalt remain a mortal and, on the expiry of that time, return to our fairy land."

Now let us leave these topics of spirits and fairies and begin a tale of the sublunary stage—this world of ours. (Ll. 1-40.)

(1)

In a city called Bharai, there lived a merchant, who owned fourteen splendid ships. With these he traded over seas and became a master of immense wealth. He made a house with profuse decorations of gold, but lived there with a sad heart, as he had no child. The house glittered like a show-thing, but the mind of its owner was ever-darkened with despair, for he considered all the wealth he had amassed to be of no purpose without an heir. His heart was sad and he bemoaned his lot in silence.

"Providence is against me," he thought, "what is the good of being near a dry canal having not a drop of water to quench one's thirst? What is the good of having a house which has no light and is covered with perpetual darkness? Even a monkey will not care to climb a tree that bears no fruit. The flower which has no honey, does not attract the bees. This my house without an heir, is joyless to me."

Thinking sadly in this strain, he came out one day for a walk in the public streets and saw a *sādhu*, going by the way. With his heart charged with sorrow, he prostrated himself at the feet of the holy man and said with tears in his eyes, "I am a miserable wretch, O master, without a child. People hate me because I am so. They turn their face to avoid looking at me.[1] Often do I wish to drown myself. It may be that this my meeting with a saint like you is due to God's grace. Can you, revered Sir, help me in my distress?" (Ll. 1-20.)

(2)

The heart of the holy man melted with compassion at the appeal of the merchant. He gave him a fruit and said, "Go home with this fruit. Let your wife eat it on a Tuesday or a Saturday. She will bear you a child,—a girl—of such exquisite beauty that the whole palace will be lighted by her presence. Through her you will have all joy and your sorrow will come to an end. But take care of one point. You must give her in marriage in her ninth year. If you foolishly allow this period to pass even by a moment, all your fourteen ships will be wrecked, your city will be destroyed by fire and the

[1] The childless man used to be called an '*atkuria*'—a wretch, and people would not like to see his face in the morning lest his whole day would go joyless, for the sight of an "*atkuria*" according to popular belief was inauspicious.

planet, Saturn, will be annoyed and burn your riches with his angry look." (Ll. 1-12.)

(3)

The merchant returned home with the fruit in his hand. The first two hours of Saturday, held inauspicious, passed away. During this time the merchant took care to wash the fruit. A quarter of an hour later, he entered the inner apartment and after another hour, he interviewed his wife. When it was about ten 'dandas' (about 9 A.M.), he placed the fruit in her hand and a quarter of an hour later, she ate the fruit, after having offered her prayers to the goddess Nava-Durga.[1]

A month passed and the lady spent the time thinking all the while if really something would come out of this. The second month she felt weak and lay mostly on her bed. In the third month, she knew that she was *enciente.* In the fifth month, the ceremony of *Pancha-mrita* was held in the palace. In the seventh month, her relations and kinsmen gave her feasts and clothes, by a ceremony called the *sādh.* In the eighth, she felt very uneasy in her mind and in the ninth, she was so unwell that she could not move. On the expiry of ten months and ten days, a beautiful girl was born of her. So resplendently handsome was the baby that the whole palace seemed to be lighted by her smile. (Ll. 1-20.)

(4)

Time rolled on. The baby grew to be a girl of nine years. Only three quarters of an hour remained to complete her ninth year.

[1] This dilatory procedure in handing over the fruit to the wife is probably due to waiting for the auspicious moment.

Her hair was flowing and long, it aspired to touch her feet and was so profuse that she seemed to feel its weight, when she walked. Her eyes were like two stars on the blue azure. Her lips were deep purple and looked as if perpetually dyed with a red paint. Her appearance looked bright like a figure of molten gold. On her breast, hang a string of pearls of rare worth and beauty.

The merchant was suddenly reminded of the words of the *Sādhu*. Only three quarters of an hour remained to complete her ninth year.

It was all their destiny. Alas, what woe was reserved for the girl! She was like a star, born in the sky but by evil luck thrown into the earth. The merciful God has no mercy for the unfortunate.

Suddenly the merchant recollected the words of the *Sādhu* and he made up his mind. Perchance the curse of the holy man might really be fulfilled. Only three quarters of an hour remained. She must either be married within this time, or his fourteen splendid ships would be all sunk in the sea and his palace destroyed by fire. As he thought over the matter, he grew firm in his resolve, "Whomsoever I happen to meet first within this time, to him shall I offer my daughter." This was his decision. What is written in one's destiny must happen. No one can wipe out the decree of one's fate, not even one's parents. (Ll. 1-24.)

(5)

At this time a Brahmin-beggar came to the merchant's door.

He was worn out with care and bent under the weight of his years. He supported himself by a stick and carried a baby in his arms. The baby was six months old and blind. With this child the old man

stood at the gate for a handful of alms. Shortly after the birth of this child, the Brahmin's wife had died. Though blind, the baby was fair to see and looked bright as a flaming fire. The old man spent his days in utmost distress, continually thinking as to how he should prepare himself for the next world. After much distressing thoughts he had come to the merchant. He said, "Be pleased, Sir, to give shelter to this baby. I will leave it to you and being released of all anxieties, start for the holy shrines of Gaya and Benares. I have spent all my life, begging from door to door. What little time I may have before death, I want to devote to making myself prepared for it—living in one of the holy cities. To add to my innumerable miseries, as if they were not already enough, God has given me this blind baby. If I can trust it to your care, I shall feel myself quite free, having no attachment for this world."

The merchant thought over the matter for a while and then took the baby from the Brahmin and carried it to his daughter. Very little time now remained. The merchant stood before his daughter with the baby in his arms. Tears fell down from his eyes, as he stood silent for a time. (Ll. 1-18.)

(6)

She was sorry to see the merchant in that condition. She addressed him with tearful eyes and said:

"Why is it, father, that you are weeping in this way? What have I done to wound your feelings thus? My mother died when I was born and you have nourished me all this time with the affection of both a father and mother. Like a cloud, pouring out rain and causing rivers and canals to overflow, your tears are flooding my mind with grief. Tell me whence you have obtained

this blind child, beautiful as flaming fire. Did its cruel mother leave it on the wayside, whence have you picked it up? Oh, what monsters must have been its parents, to leave it thus uncared for! The poor baby, alas, has no eyes to see the Sun and the Moon! How miserable is this child from birth! Its whole life will indeed be like one long night." (Ll. 1-20.)

(7)

The merchant began to sob aloud as he heard his daughter's words. It was not a thing to be spoken out. Yet it must be spoken. The merchant wept and thus related the whole story:

"I was childless and people called me names and hated me for being so. By chance I met a Sannyasi, who gave me a fruit. Your mother ate it and as a result, we have got you, darling, our best treasure. But woe to my luck! Well it is that your mother is dead. Had she lived to-day, she would not be able to bear the insupportable grief of this hour. It was settled that at your ninth year, you must be given in marriage. If the ninth year was allowed to pass and you remained unmarried, evil luck would pursue me. My fourteen ships would be lost in the sea with their cargo and my palace destroyed. This was the oracle delivered by the Sannyasi. Think not that I have remained idle all these nine years. All along I have sought for a suitable bridegroom, but none could I find, to my choice.[1] There remain only a few minutes for

[1] In Canto IV, it is stated that the merchant had forgotten all about the prophecy of the Sannyasi and was suddenly reminded of it in the eleventh hour. But here he gives a different story. These anomalies are due to the faulty narrations of the rustic folk who not infrequently miss the proper links in their narratives and give accounts of an inconsistent nature. It should be remembered that these ballads and songs were not written, and the errors and inconsistencies have occurred owing to faulty memory.

you to complete the ninth year. How can I now keep you in this house as an unmarried girl? Strange to say, at this critical moment, a Brahmin beggar came to my house and leaving this blind child to my care, has gone to visit the holy shrines of Gaya and Benares. Now take over the child to your custody. It was ordained by luck that you should have a blind baby for your husband. How could this be helped?" (Ll. 1-24.)

(8)

The roaring of the clouds filled the whole expanse of the sky. The deep sound was like the call of sympathy from heaven. On the boughs of trees sat the forest-birds and sang a note of wailing. She wept and reflected, "Alas, my father has turned my enemy. God is against me. The path before me is dark, not illumined by a single star or moonbeams. In this stream of life, I have not a ferry-boat to help me in crossing it. A brother's affection is a great treasure. I have unhappily no brother born here. Here in this very room, my mother used to comb my hair. Alas! This unfortunate one will never see her any more, nor feel that tender embrace. There is nothing so sweet as the morning-breeze, and one's mother's call of affection in childhood. Alas! that sweet voice will never cool my burning heart. Had she been living, surely she would not have given me this blind baby for a husband. How can I blame my father? It is all the work of my evil luck. O Sun and Moon, bear witness; and you, little baby in my arms, bear witness, too. I elect you as my husband, as my father has wished. From to-day Kānchanmālā is lost to him and lost to all happiness."

For a long time she bewailed her lot and then when night drew her dark veil over the world, she left the

Kanchanmala



"I will try to read your future to-morrow and offer you what help I can." P. 93.

palace and the city of her father—Bharainagar. As she wandered forth in the forest, she called its fierce dwellers—the bears and tigers—and asked them to eat her up, sparing her little husband. "It rent my heart," she said, "in twain, to leave the city of Bharainagar and my father's palace." The strange and unknown path faded in the depth of darkness. The sun shone like a mark of the red paint, vermilion, on the brow of the firmament—so dense was the forest. The day gave a glamour, not brighter than the evening, so dense was the forest. The wilderness, dark as it was, grew terrible in the night—her only companion, a small blind child. There she came near a large and ancient fig-tree. It was there since the Age of Truth (Satya Yuga). She approached the tree with the prayer that it might afford her a shelter for the night. "Lord of the forest art thou, O noble tree, save this little child. Be like a parent to this unfortunate one." Praying in this manner, she gave three gentle strokes at the tree, which instantly opened itself and showed a cavity inside.

(Ll. 1-36.)

(9)

From this hollow of the tree, came out a *Sannyasi* and asked Kānchanmālā as to whence she came and whither she was going in that dark night, whereupon she related to him her whole story.

The Sannyāsi.

"I leave my seat in this cavity. Sleep here with the baby for this night. I will try to read your future to-morrow and offer you what help I can."

The clouds glistened in the eastern sky, which glowed with a yellowish light. The Sannyasi stood near Kānchanmālā at the dawn of the day and said :

"You were once in great happiness, being born in the family of a rich man. But great sufferings await you. These are due to your evil luck and there is no remedy for them.

"I give you this fruit. Let the babe eat it. He will gain his eyesight. As you will proceed on the way, you will meet with woodsmen. Follow them and live in their company. There your husband will grow into his youth. If you ever happen to fall into a danger, remember me, and I will try to help you." (Ll. 1-13.)

(10)

Kānchanmālā gave the fruit to the child to eat. As soon as he had tasted of it, his eye-lids opened. He was a cripple from birth, but his body became straight and well-proportioned. It was as if a corpse came back to life, at the touch of a magician's wand, so did the baby thrive, tasting of that divine fruit.

Proceeding on his way, she espied the huts of woodsmen, as the Sannyasi had told her.

An old woodman and his good wife had founded there a small colony of their kinsmen. The small huts were built with creepers and wild plants which looked fresh and beautiful. The woodsmen carried wood and fuel on their heads to market-places and sold them to customers and thus earned their living. The women had smiling faces, pleasant to look at, like the full moon. They lived there happily with their husbands and children. Their hair was curly and they wore bark-dresses. They all came to see Kānchanmālā, as she approached their huts.

"Where is your home, dear girl? What is the village called? Why have you come to this wilderness of ours? How cruel must be your parents to have the

heart to send you thus away. Tell us all the facts, without hiding anything. Your villagemen must be hard-hearted people to send you to this wild land. You are so beautiful! You look like a fairy. And they had the heart to send one of your tender age all alone! If you have done any wrong, what could be the fault of this baby, bright as the moon. How could they bear to send the sweet child in this way? It seems, your parents are void of all tenderness and affection. How are they bearing their life without you?"

Kānchanmālā.

"No father, no mother have I. Like a weed, carried by the current, I wander about helplessly, driven by Fate. That I am here in this forest is neither the fault of my parents nor of the people of my village. It is all due to my ill-luck."

In that place, the old woodsman and his good wife had no children. They welcomed the girl and the baby in their house. Kānchanmālā went with the woodswomen and cut trees. The very path she trod became lit up with her graceful presence, so beautiful did she look. The woodsmen and their wives wondered as to who this little Queen of beauty was.

Some said, she was a fairy, others held her to be a princess. One admirer said, she must be the spirit of the moon, dropped from the sky; and a fourth swore that she was Lakshmi herself, the Goddess of harvest. She had come thither to taste the joys of forest-life. But all agreed in believing that she was vouchsafed to that forest to remove the sorrows of poor woodsmen. They bowed their head down to her secretly, paying the whole-hearted and grateful respects of their soul.

Four years passed in this way. The woodsmen, during all this time, sold their goods at fourfold their usual price. They were firmly convinced that they owned their extraordinary good luck to her grace and that she was a goddess in disguise.

The little baby now grew to be a lad of six years.

(Ll. 1-32.)

(10)

One day it so happened that the prince of a neighbouring country came to that forest-land for hunting. The women of the poor people took Kānchanmālā there in their company, and while they themselves carried loads of wood, presented fruits gathered there, to her, as a token of their love. She tied these in the flowing end of her *sari* and cheerfully walked about with them.

The prince saw the lad Phulkumar, who was hunting birds in the company of the children of woodsmen.

He was barely six and strikingly handsome. The prince looked at him with eyes of curiosity. He was convinced that such a child could not be a woodsman's son. He called the child to his presence and looked intently at him. He was surprised to mark, on the forehead of the boy, signs of noble birth. The unique sign of royalty—the *raj tika* shone from his brows. The prince was surprised and pleased and ordered his men to carry the child to his palace. "If he does not agree to go, of his own accord, bind him by force and carry him to my city." This was his order.

As soon as the order was passed, his soldiers laid siege to the whole tract, inhabited by the peaceful woodsmen and destroyed their huts, even as wicked boys break the nests of birds, built on tree-tops. The wood-boys ran away to their homes. All lamented the loss, done by the prince's soldiers. Their small money was

looted by these robbers. They sat in despair, reflecting sadly on their heavy loss. Some of them cried and sobbed aloud and others wept in silence.

But poor Kānchanmālā was maddened with grief, losing her little husband. Like the fabled jewel on the hood of a serpent, which if taken away, it dies, was the lad a dear treasure of the chaste wife's heart. Parted, for a moment, from him, she felt her life unsupportable.

Alas, the grief of a true wife! As a boat sinks in a muddy pool without a man to steer it, what woe befalls the lot of a wife, deserted by her husband! What is left of a woman, whose husband has left her? She looks like a house, of which the lights have been put out. She may possess wealth, high rank and a retinue of servants and dependants. What will all these avail her? The stars cannot illuminate the sky, though they are many, if there is no moon. Like the sun in the sky and lamp in the house is the husband prized by a woman, who is chaste.

This life, alas, is unbearable without a husband. A woman, deserted by her husband, becomes an object of ridicule by all. Some abuse her openly, and others do so behind her back.

Thus did Kānchanmālā lament and her wild cries and piteous wail made even the beasts of the forest and the birds of the air cry in sympathy and grief. (Ll. 1-46.)

(11)

Kānchanmālā wandered about like a mad woman, seeking her husband, in the company of the old woodsman, her foster-father.

In the Sundhā-methi-Valley, where men were like monsters and lived upon human flesh—in the far-off Jigâ-hills, where men lived together with serpents, and

where tigers and bears killed them every year by hundreds—in the Gāro hills, where the Kookis and Garos lived, a set of wicked savages of the North, who had acquired great physical strength by eating human flesh and wandered about, in a state of complete nudity in the forests—Kānchanmālā travelled like a mad soul, searching her little husband. She often slipped her foot on the stones of the hilly country and got severe hurt and she sobbed aloud in pain. No one came to solace her by sympathetic words. In the deserts, where the sands were so hot as if they were fried on fire, uncomplainingly did she go on foot, which burnt and became full of sores. But she heeded not all these sufferings. For six years, she searched her husband through hills and dales, through deserts and plains and at last reached a city, named Soomāi. (Ll. 1-20.)

(12)

The name of the Raja there was Vidyādhara. He had a very handsome daughter, named Kunjalatā. When Kānchanmālā arrived at that city, she heard the drummers beating drums, with the proclamation that a maid-servant was required in the palace for the princess Kunjalatā.

When Kānchan heard this proclamation, she saw the woodman and his wife, who had all along travelled with her, and requested their permission to offer her services as maid-servant to the princess Kunjalatā, saying, "O my mother of the woods, I am fatigued and can no longer travel. Your daughter bids you farewell. O my foster-father, you have been ever kind to this girl for all these years. Forgive and forget all the faults of this child. Do not, I pray you, be unhappy on my account, remembering the past and the sweet affection that has bound me to you all this time. I never remember

to have seen my mother. But you have been tender to me in our forest-home and shown me a truly paternal affection. To-day I am going to start my life anew; my tale of sorrows, the thousand things of our forest life, will remain untold for ever. From to-day, think that your Kāncḥanmālā is no more in this world, and no more feel any anxiety for my sake."

The woodman's wife began to sob aloud at this and said, "The pain, dear girl, I feel at parting with you can not be expressed in words. We had no children, but got a child in you. You have been, to us, like a treasure, unexpectedly found by a poor man. The cool shade of our fig trees and the fresh water of the hill stream have, alas, no more any charm for you! If you would leave us in this way, why did you allow our affection to grow thus!"

It was by a mere chance that they had become united in affection. The girl and her foster-mother embraced each other and wept. (Ll. 1-14.)

(13)

Kānchanmālā laid her hands on the drum of the public drummer. As soon as she did so, the soldiers of the Raja approached and looked up for the person, who was her guardian. She was selected and they found out the woodman and satisfied him by offering a lakh of rupees as the price of the girl.

Then did the people of the Raja take Kānchanmālā to his inner court.

Now I am going to relate what happened next.

The same lad—once the baby husband of Kānchan,—had married the princess Kunjalatā in due course. The young bridegroom and Kunja spent their life in great happiness in a lovely bower, attached to the palace. Like a peacock, with its mate in a rich man's garden,

did they happily reside in their apartments. Like the pigeon, which gently touches the beak of his mate with his, and sweetly spends the time, did the happy pair remain together without knowing any sorrow.

One day Kunjalatā asked her lord to relate to her in full the story of his forest-life.

Kunjalatā.

"When a mere child, you were nursed in a woodland; how could you live in the forest, infested with tigers and bears? Who are your parents? What place was your native land? What made you come to the forest and live there? You are so handsome that kings take fancy for you. How is it that you were banished in the forest? What makes you sad on occasions and sigh like one, who hides a deep wound in his heart?"

Phulkumār.

"No father, no mother, had I. Your father carried me away from the forest, taking pity on my forlorn condition.

"Our forest-life, dear lady, was a very happy one."

Saying this, he seemed to hesitate and hide something. The princess, perceiving this, said with great eagerness.

Kunjalatā.

"Tell me all facts of your forest-life. How do I wish to hear the account from your own lips? Do not hide anything from me. I am your wife—your beloved; why should you not open your mind freely to me?"

Phulkumār.

"In the depths of the forest did we live. Our days passed happily. A beautiful maiden looked after me. She was handsome beyond all description. I remember